

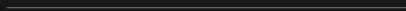


The Key Teachings of
A. B. SIMPSON



Christ is all, and in all.

COLOSSIANS 3:11



OCHORUS

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Unless otherwise indicated, all Scripture quotations are taken from the Authorised (King James) Version, the version Simpson preached and wrote from.

A note on chapter four. That chapter concerns Simpson's teaching on divine healing. Nothing in this book should be taken as counselling any reader to decline, delay or discontinue medical treatment. Please read the cautions set out there, and consult a qualified physician about your health.

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Introduction

Where there is neither Greek nor Jew ...but Christ is all, and in all.

COLOSSIANS 3:11

Among the men whose names are attached to the deeper-life movement, A. B. Simpson is the one most likely to be unfamiliar to the reader, and the one whose fingerprints are most widely distributed.

He founded a worldwide missionary movement that now numbers in the millions. He established the first Bible institute in North America, and the pattern he invented has been copied on every continent. He wrote around a hundred books and more than a hundred hymns. He shaped, directly or at one remove, the theology of a great deal of twentieth-century evangelical devotion — A. W. Tozer was his spiritual son and wrote his biography. And most Christians who have absorbed his emphases have never heard his name.

A summary in four words

Simpson's teaching is unusually easy to summarise, because he summarised it himself. He called it the Fourfold Gospel, and he preached it for forty years:

Christ our Saviour. Christ our Sanctifier. Christ our Healer. Christ our Coming King.

The structure matters less than what it is built to do. Notice that all four begin with the same word. Simpson was not offering four doctrines but one Person in four relations, and this was the whole point. When a prominent healing evangelist once invited him to spend himself on a nationwide healing campaign, Simpson replied that he had four wheels on his chariot and could not neglect three of them to devote himself to one.

That instinct — for wholeness, for keeping things in proportion, for refusing to make any single emphasis the whole — is his most valuable characteristic, and it is what makes him worth reading in an age of ministries built on one idea.

Himself, not it

But beneath the four wheels lies something simpler still, and it is the reason Simpson belongs in this series.

His most quoted hymn opens by describing a change he had passed through: that once it had been the blessing, and now it was the Lord;

once the feeling, and now the Word; once His gifts he wanted, and now the Giver alone. The hymn is called *Himself*, and the title is the whole of his theology.

Simpson had spent years pursuing spiritual experiences — a deeper consecration, a fuller blessing, the power he saw in others — and had found that each arrival was followed by a fresh emptiness. What broke the cycle was the discovery that Christ does not primarily give things. Christ gives Himself, and everything else is contained in Him.

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ.

EPHESIANS 1:3

That is the thread running through all eighteen chapters of this book, and it is the question to keep asking as you read: *am I seeking something from Him, or am I seeking Him?*

How this book is arranged

Eighteen short chapters set out his teaching, beginning with that central emphasis, moving through the four wheels of the chariot, then into his teaching on the self life and the Christ life, the Holy Spirit, faith and prayer, and finally to the two things that consumed the last half of his life: the forgotten poor at his door, and the unreached nations beyond the sea.

Each chapter ends with application points and a prayer. Simpson would have insisted on it. He had no patience with truth that stopped at the understanding, and he measured every doctrine by whether it produced a changed life and a worker sent out.

Read one chapter a day, or one a week. Stop at the application points. Pray the prayer, or better, pray your own.

One more thing must be said at the outset, and it is better said plainly.

This is not a book of hero-worship, and there are places where Simpson must be read with care.

His teaching on divine healing has been a blessing to many and has done real damage to others. Simpson himself, after his own healing in 1881, set aside medical treatment entirely and taught others to trust Christ alone for the body. Some of those who followed him died of treatable conditions. Some were told, or concluded, that their continued illness proved a deficiency of faith — a cruelty that has crushed sincere believers ever since. Chapter four sets out what he taught, what is genuinely biblical in it, and where it must be qualified. Please read that chapter with its cautions rather than without them.

His doctrine of sanctification as a definite second crisis, received by faith after conversion, is held by many godly Christians and rejected

by many others who read the same passages differently. This book presents it as he taught it and notes honestly where the disagreement lies.

And his expectation that the gospel might be carried to every nation within his own generation, hastening the Lord's return, proved mistaken — as every such expectation has. The burden was right. The timetable was not.

Why read him at all, then? Because on the central matter he was profoundly right, and because he lived what he taught at considerable cost. He walked away from the most comfortable pulpits available to a man of his gifts, twice, to work among people nobody else wanted. He gave away money he needed. He sent out hundreds of missionaries to places from which many did not return, and he buried his own children.

So the counsel of this book is the counsel of Scripture: *Prove all things; hold fast that which is good* (1 Thessalonians 5:21). Weigh every chapter against the Word of God. Where Simpson is faithful — and on the all-sufficiency of Christ, on the indwelling Spirit, on the missionary obligation of the whole church, he is faithful indeed — receive it gladly and act upon it. Where he presses beyond what is written, mark it, set it aside, and lose nothing.

A final word about the reader this book assumes.

Simpson wrote for late nineteenth-century North Americans, in a city filling with immigrants, at a moment when the modern missionary movement was gathering force. He is read now in places he prayed for and never saw. The movement he founded is today far larger outside the country he worked in than within it, which would have delighted him and not surprised him at all.

He assumed no particular setting, because his subject was not a culture but a Person. Wherever this book is opened, and into whatever language it is carried, the question it presses will already be waiting.

A Man with Four Wheels on His Chariot

I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me.

PHILIPPIANS 4:13

A Scottish covenanting home. Albert Benjamin Simpson was born on the fifteenth of December, 1843, at Bayview on Prince Edward Island, off the eastern coast of Canada. His parents, James and Janet Simpson, were Scottish, Presbyterian, and severe in the old covenanting way. His father was a shipbuilder and merchant and an elder in the church; the Sabbath was kept without compromise and the catechism was learned.

A depression struck the maritime trade in the late 1840s, the family business failed, and they moved west to Chatham in Ontario. The boy grew up in a home of reduced circumstances, religious discipline and considerable anxiety.

He was a nervous, conscientious child, and his religion made him miserable. He believed the doctrines and could not find peace in them, and he wore himself into a physical collapse trying. It was the first of several breakdowns that would mark his life.

The first good work. Relief came through a book. In his fifteenth year, during a season of revival in Chatham under the preaching of a visiting Irish evangelist, he came upon Walter Marshall's old Puritan treatise *The Gospel Mystery of Sanctification*, and read a sentence that undid the knot: that the first good work a man will ever perform is to believe on the Lord Jesus Christ.

He had been trying to produce a fitness to come. He saw that believing was the coming. He did not receive a rush of feeling — he was honest about that all his life — but he became settled that Christ had received him. In January 1861 he wrote out a formal covenant giving himself to God, and signed it.

He entered Knox College, Toronto, and graduated in 1865.

Three prestigious pulpits. What followed was a career of relentless external success and quiet internal dissatisfaction.

At twenty-one he was called to Knox Presbyterian Church in Hamilton, Ontario, one of the largest congregations in Canada. He married Margaret Henry two days after his ordination examinations, and was back in his pulpit the following Sunday. He worked ferociously and added some seven hundred members in eight years.

The Hamilton years also brought the first grief. Their second son, Melville Jennings, died at three years old. Simpson wrote afterwards that until then he had gone to bereaved families with sympathy that was honestly meant and touched nothing, because he had no acquaintance with sorrow of his own. Two of their six children were buried young.

In December 1873 he moved to Chestnut Street Presbyterian in Louisville, Kentucky, the leading Presbyterian pulpit in that city. There he pressed for united evangelistic meetings across the denominations, and built a plain tabernacle so that working men who owned no good clothes could come without embarrassment. It succeeded, and his congregation was not entirely pleased.

In 1879 he was called to Thirteenth Street Presbyterian Church in New York City, and arrived to find the thing that would define the rest of his life: hundreds of thousands of immigrants pouring into a city whose respectable churches had no intention of receiving them.

Two crises. Two experiences turned him, and they came five years apart.

The first was in 1874, at Louisville. Exhausted and conscious that his ministry ran on his own strength, he read W. E. Boardman's *The Higher Christian Life* and came into what he afterwards described as the reception of Christ as his sanctification — not a new effort but a new dependence. He dated his real ministry from it.

The second was in the summer of 1881. He had been ill for years with a heart condition; a physician in New York had given him three months. At the conference grounds at Old Orchard Beach in Maine he heard Dr Charles Cullis teach on divine healing, and was more struck by the testimonies than the argument. On a Friday afternoon in August he went alone into the pine woods and made a threefold pledge: that he accepted the Bible's teaching that Jesus is the healer of the body; that he took Him then and there as his own physical life for all the needs of his body until his life-work was done; and that he would use the strength given him for the glory of God and the service of others.

He came out of the woods changed. The following day he climbed a mountain of three thousand feet. He lived another thirty-eight years, and worked at a pace that exhausted much younger men.

The break. That autumn he asked his congregation to receive a group of Italian immigrant converts into membership. They declined.

In November 1881 he resigned — a settled salary, a distinguished pulpit, and the denomination in which he had been raised and ordained — with no congregation, no income, and seven children. He was baptised by immersion in a Baptist church in New York early the following year.

He began preaching in a hall to a handful of people. Within a few

years the Gospel Tabernacle was one of the most vigorous congregations in the city, and it was doing what nobody else was doing: rescue missions, work among the poor, an orphanage, homes where the sick could stay and be prayed for, and services for immigrants in their own languages.

Institutions built to send people away. In 1882 he opened a missionary training school — the first Bible institute in North America — on the conviction that ordinary believers with practical training and a call could be got to the field in two years rather than seven. It later moved up the Hudson to Nyack. Nearly every Bible college in the world descends from that idea.

At Old Orchard in 1887 he founded two societies: the Christian Alliance, for the deepening of spiritual life at home, and the Evangelical Missionary Alliance, to send workers abroad. In 1897 they merged into The Christian and Missionary Alliance.

He never intended a denomination. He wanted a movement inside the existing churches — a fellowship of people from every tradition united by the Fourfold Gospel and the evangelisation of the world. It became a denomination anyway, which is what usually happens.

Meanwhile he edited a weekly magazine for nearly forty years, wrote around a hundred books including a commentary on the whole Bible, and composed more than a hundred hymns, often producing the words on Saturday for the congregation to sing on Sunday.

The Pentecostal question. After 1906 the Pentecostal revival swept through the movements nearest to his own, and many Alliance people were caught up in it.

Simpson's response was characteristically balanced and satisfied nobody entirely. He longed for more of the Spirit's power, and in August 1907 returned to the same pine woods at Old Orchard to ask God for a fuller baptism. He did not speak in tongues, then or later. He concluded that tongues is a genuine gift which God distributes as He wills, and that it is not the necessary evidence of the Spirit's fullness — and he set the policy that has marked the Alliance since: *seek not, forbid not*.

The cost was real. The movement lost members in both directions, to those who wanted more and to those who wanted the door shut.

The end. His last years were hard. He grew frail, his memory failed, and he passed through a period of spiritual darkness that his friends found painful to watch in a man who had taught so many others about victory. He stepped back from leadership in 1918.

He went into a coma on the twenty-eighth of October, 1919, and died the following day at Nyack, aged seventy-five.

He left no fortune. He left a training school, a magazine, a hymnbook,

a tabernacle full of poor people, and several hundred missionaries scattered across the world in places he had never seen and had prayed for by name.

Himself

For in him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily. And ye are complete in him.

COLOSSIANS 2:9–10

Simpson wrote a hymn which is still sung in places that have forgotten who wrote it, and its title is a single word: *Himself*.

The verses trace a movement. They describe a man who once sought the blessing and now seeks the Lord; who once lived on feelings and now rests on the Word; who once wanted the gifts and now wants only the Giver; who once was always asking and now is always praising. Each verse makes the same turn — from something Christ provides to Christ Himself.

It is autobiography. And it is the key to everything else in this book.

The exhausting pursuit of it

Simpson had spent his early ministry in a condition that many earnest Christians will recognise immediately.

He was successful. He was orthodox. He worked to the point of physical collapse — more than once. And he was aware that something was missing, and set about looking for it in the way conscientious people do: by seeking a further experience. A deeper consecration. A fuller blessing. The power he could see in others and could not find in himself.

The trouble with this pursuit is that each arrival is followed by a fresh emptiness. You obtain the blessing, and within weeks you need another. Your Christian life becomes a series of peaks with lengthening valleys between them, and your spiritual health comes to depend on how recently you were last at a convention.

Simpson's escape from this was not a better experience. It was the discovery that he had been asking for the wrong category of thing altogether.

Christ does not primarily give things

The insight, once stated, seems almost too simple to have cost so much.

Christ does not chiefly dispense blessings, as a benefactor distributes gifts from a store. He gives Himself, and every blessing is contained within Him rather than handed out beside Him.

But of him are ye in Christ Jesus, who of God is made unto us wisdom, and righteousness, and sanctification, and redemption.

Read that slowly. Paul does not say Christ gives us wisdom, righteousness, sanctification and redemption. He says Christ *is made unto* us these things. They are not commodities He supplies; they are what He is to us. To have Him is to have them, and to seek them apart from Him is to look for light somewhere other than the sun.

And of his fulness have all we received, and grace for grace.

JOHN 1:16

Simpson's whole Fourfold Gospel rests on this. He did not preach salvation, sanctification, healing and the second coming as four topics. He preached Christ our Saviour, Christ our Sanctifier, Christ our Healer, Christ our Coming King — four relations to one Person. Take away the Person and you are left with four doctrines, which is a different and much poorer thing.

The test

There is a question Simpson's teaching puts to a believer, and it is not comfortable.

Suppose God gave you nothing further as long as you live. No answered prayer you are currently waiting on. No relief from the circumstance that is grinding you. No further usefulness, no growth you can detect, no experience to report. Would Christ Himself still be enough?

Whom have I in heaven but thee? and there is none upon earth that I desire beside thee.

PSALM 73:25

Most of us discover, asking that honestly, that a good deal of what we call love for God is love for what He does for us — and that our devotion rises and falls with His recent performance. That discovery is not a reason for despair. It is the beginning of the change Simpson's hymn describes.

He was careful to add that this does not make the blessings unimportant. God gives real gifts and means them to be enjoyed. The question is one of order. Seek the gift and you may get it and remain empty; seek the Giver and the gifts arrive as part of the package, held loosely, no longer able to make or break you.

But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.

MATTHEW 6:33

Where this leaves the restless

The practical relief in this teaching is considerable, and it is why Simpson mattered so much to the exhausted.

If what you need is an experience, then you must keep obtaining it, and you are permanently vulnerable — to your temperament, your health, your circumstances, the quality of last Sunday's meeting. If what you need is a Person, and that Person indwells you and has promised never to leave, then your supply does not fluctuate even when your sense of it does.

For he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee.

HEBREWS 13:5

Simpson taught believers to stop asking for more of the Holy Spirit and to start recognising how much of them the Holy Spirit had. The problem was never the supply.

There is a way to test whether this has moved from theory into practice, and it takes about a week to apply.

Listen to your own praying. Count how much of it asks Christ for something, and how much of it simply wants Him. Most of us find the second column almost empty, and we have been calling the first column a devotional life.

Leanness of soul

There is a verse in the Psalms which describes the danger of getting what you asked for, and Simpson returned to it often.

And he gave them their request; but sent leanness into their soul.

PSALM 106:15

Israel in the wilderness wanted meat. They complained until they got it. God granted the petition exactly as made, and something was lost in the granting that they had not thought to protect.

The warning is not that God punishes us for asking. It is that a request granted on our own terms may leave us thinner than we were, because what we actually needed was not the thing but the God who was withholding it, and we were too busy negotiating to notice.

Simpson applied this directly to the pursuit of spiritual experiences. A believer may set his heart on a particular blessing — an experience of power, a healing, a ministry, a resolution to some long trouble — and pursue it with real earnestness, and receive it, and find himself no closer to God than before. There is a leanness that can coexist with answered prayer.

The remedy is not to stop asking. It is to want the Giver more than the gift, so that the answer, when it comes, arrives into a life already centred somewhere else.

Delight thyself also in the Lord; and he shall give thee the desires of thine heart.

PSALM 37:4

That verse is often read as a promise that God will supply whatever we want if we are sufficiently devout. Simpson read it the other way round, and the grammar supports him: the delight comes first, and it is in the process of delighting in the Lord that our desires themselves are changed into things He is glad to give.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask the hard question directly: if God gave you nothing more, would Christ Himself be enough? Tell Him your honest answer rather than the correct one.
2. Audit a week of your prayers. What proportion sought a gift, and what proportion sought the Giver?
3. Identify one blessing you have been pursuing as though it were separable from Christ. Seek Him, and let it come as part of Him.
4. Notice whether your spiritual wellbeing depends on how recently you had a strong experience. If it does, that is the pattern Simpson escaped.
5. Spend fifteen minutes this week asking God for nothing at all, and simply attending to Him.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, I have wanted Your blessings more than I have wanted You, and I have called that devotion.

I have chased experiences and been empty a fortnight later. I have measured my spiritual health by how I felt on Sunday. Forgive me.

You are made unto me wisdom, righteousness, sanctification and redemption. I do not need a supply of these things. I need You, and I have You.

Be my portion. Let me want the Giver, and let the gifts fall where they will. Amen.

Christ Our Saviour

Neither is there salvation in any other: for there is none other name under heaven given among men, whereby we must be saved.

ACTS 4:12

The first wheel of the chariot is the one every Christian assumes he has already understood, and Simpson's treatment of it is worth attention precisely because of how he came to it.

A boy who could not get in

He was raised in a rigorous Scottish Presbyterian home, catechised thoroughly, and made thoroughly wretched by it. He believed every doctrine he had been taught. He could not find peace in any of them.

The difficulty was not intellectual. It was that he understood himself to be required to arrive at some condition — sufficient repentance, adequate sorrow, a certain quality of surrender — before he could come to Christ. And every time he examined himself he found the condition unmet. He drove himself into a physical collapse trying to produce it.

What released him, at fifteen, was a sentence in an old Puritan book: that the first good work a man will ever perform is to believe on the Lord Jesus Christ.

He saw it. He had been trying to become fit to come, and the coming was the fitness. There was nothing to bring.

But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness.

ROMANS 4:5

He was honest all his life that no great emotion accompanied this. He simply took what was offered, and afterwards became settled that Christ had received him. Feelings came later, and irregularly, and he never allowed them to be the foundation.

More than pardon

But Simpson's distinctive emphasis lies elsewhere, and it shapes everything that follows in his teaching.

Salvation, as he preached it, is not merely the cancelling of a debt. It is the impartation of a life.

He that hath the Son hath life; and he that hath not the Son of God hath not life.

1 JOHN 5:12

A man may be forgiven and remain what he was. If salvation were pardon only, the sinner would leave the courtroom acquitted and unchanged, facing the same future with the same nature. What Scripture describes is birth — a new category of existence, with a life in it that was not there before.

Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:17

This is why Simpson could move so naturally from the first wheel to the second. If salvation is the impartation of Christ's life, then sanctification is not a separate programme requiring different machinery. It is the same life, further received.

Christ our salvation, not merely its author

Notice the grammar of the Fourfold Gospel again. Not *Christ the giver of salvation*, but *Christ our Saviour* — and Simpson pressed even that into the possessive.

The Lord is my strength and song, and is become my salvation.

EXODUS 15:2

Is become my salvation. Not *has provided* it. The Old Testament says this repeatedly, and Simpson would not let the phrase be flattened into a figure of speech. Christ does not stand outside us holding our salvation; He enters, and is it.

The practical difference shows up when a believer sins. If salvation is a thing you were given, then failure raises the question of whether you still have it, and the anxious conscience spends its life auditing. If salvation is a Person who has taken up residence, the question changes entirely: not *do I still possess it?* but *is He still there?* — and He has answered that Himself.

And I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish, neither shall any man pluck them out of my hand.

JOHN 10:28

Free, and therefore urgent

One further note, because it explains the rest of Simpson's life.

The freeness of salvation did not make him casual about it. It made him frantic.

A man who believes that salvation must be earned may reasonably conclude that most people will not manage it, and settle into resignation. A man who believes it is free, complete and available to anyone who will simply take it, cannot be calm about the fact that millions have never been told. Simpson's missionary passion was not a separate en-

thusiasm bolted onto his theology. It was the direct consequence of what he believed about grace.

How then shall they call on him in whom they have not believed? and how shall they believe in him of whom they have not heard? and how shall they hear without a preacher?

ROMANS 10:14

If you have carried a quiet suspicion that you must reach some standard before God will fully receive you, the sentence that freed a miserable fifteen-year-old in Ontario is worth sitting with.

The first good work you will ever do is to believe on the Lord Jesus Christ. Everything else follows. Nothing else precedes.

Assurance without feeling

Simpson's own conversion supplies a useful lesson for a very common difficulty.

He took Christ at fifteen and felt nothing. For some time afterwards he was troubled by the absence, because he had heard others describe a flood of joy at their conversion and could report no such thing. He concluded eventually that he had been looking for evidence in the wrong place.

The New Testament grounds assurance not in the quality of an experience but in the reliability of a word.

These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life.

1 JOHN 5:13

John says he wrote so that believers might *know* — and the instrument of that knowing is the thing written, not the emotion felt.

Simpson's counsel to the anxious was accordingly simple and unromantic. Do not examine your feelings to discover whether you are saved; examine what God has promised to those who come, and then determine whether you have come.

All that the Father giveth me shall come to me; and him that cometh to me I will in no wise cast out.

JOHN 6:37

He noticed the double negative in that promise — *in no wise* — and regarded it as deliberate. The Lord appears to have anticipated exactly the person who would come and then doubt whether he had been received.

None of this makes feeling worthless. Simpson had plenty of it later, and wrote hymns out of it. The point is one of foundation: emotion is a good deal more enjoyable than fact and a great deal less reliable, and a house built on it will move whenever its owner is tired, ill or discouraged.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Name the condition you have been quietly trying to meet before you believe God fully accepts you. Then stop trying to meet it.
2. Check whether your assurance rests on feeling or on what God has said. If feeling, deliberately move the weight.
3. Consider whether you think of salvation as a transaction you received or a Person who lives in you. The second changes how you handle failure.
4. If you have never definitely taken Christ, do it now, in the plainest words you can manage. There is nothing to bring.
5. Let the freeness of the gospel produce urgency rather than complacency. Name one person who has never clearly heard it.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, I have spent years trying to become fit to come to You, and the coming was the fitness all along.

I bring nothing. I have nothing to bring. I take what You have offered because You have offered it, and not because I have qualified.

Be my salvation — not a gift held at a distance, but Yourself living in me.

*And having received freely, let me not be calm about those who have never been told.
Amen.*

Christ Our Sanctifier

And the very God of peace sanctify you wholly ...Faithful is he that calleth you, who also will do it.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:23–24

In 1874, at Louisville, Simpson was pastoring the leading Presbyterian church in the city and was privately at the end of himself.

He was working at a pace that would break him, and he knew the work was running on his own resources. He was orthodox, admired and dry. Reading W. E. Boardman's *The Higher Christian Life*, he came into what he afterwards called the reception of Christ as his sanctification — and he dated the real beginning of his ministry from it.

Not achievement but reception

The heart of Simpson's teaching here is contained in a preposition.

Most believers approach holiness as something to be *achieved*. We identify our faults, resolve, apply effort, monitor progress, and fail with tiresome regularity. Sanctification becomes a self-improvement project in religious language, and its characteristic products are exhaustion and pretence.

Simpson taught that holiness is to be *received*, because it is not a quality but a Person.

But of him are ye in Christ Jesus, who of God is made unto us wisdom, and righteousness, and sanctification, and redemption.

1 CORINTHIANS 1:30

Christ is our sanctification in exactly the sense that He is our righteousness. We did not manufacture the second and we shall not manufacture the first. The same Christ who was received for pardon is received for holiness, by the same faith, on the same terms.

As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in him.

COLOSSIANS 2:6

As ye have received — that is, by faith, freely, as a gift. *So walk* — by the same method, all the way down.

The branch and the vine

Simpson's governing image, like that of most deeper-life teachers, is the vine.

Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, except it abide in the vine; no more can ye, except ye abide in me.

He drew out the point that a branch does not produce fruit by effort. It bears fruit — which is a passive verb — because sap from another source flows through it. The branch's whole responsibility is connection.

This is not an invitation to inactivity, and Simpson's own schedule refutes any such reading. He worked harder than almost anyone of his generation. The question is not whether the Christian labours but whose energy the labour runs on.

Whereunto I also labour, striving according to his working, which worketh in me mightily.

COLOSSIANS 1:29

Paul labours; he strives; and he does it according to an energy that is not his. Simpson considered that verse the exact description of the sanctified life.

Crisis and process

Here we come to the part of his teaching that is contested, and it should be set out plainly.

Simpson held that sanctification involves a definite crisis — a moment at which the believer, having seen his own insufficiency, deliberately hands over the whole of himself and takes Christ by faith as his holiness. He did not regard this as optional or as a refinement for advanced Christians. He thought most believers were living far below their privileges because they had never made that transaction.

He was equally clear that the crisis is not the end. What follows is a lifetime of growth, in which the surrender made once must be maintained daily and applied to territory not yet surveyed.

But grow in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ.

2 PETER 3:18

Now the honest qualification. Many careful Christians read the New Testament differently. They hold that sanctification begins at conversion and proceeds gradually throughout life, that Scripture nowhere teaches a distinct second crisis, and that Simpson's framework can leave believers either presuming on an experience they once had or despairing because they cannot locate one. The Reformed tradition in which Simpson himself was raised takes broadly this view.

The reader should feel free to weigh it. What is not in dispute — and it is the substance of the chapter — is that holiness is Christ's work in us rather than our achievement, that it is appropriated by faith rather than manufactured by resolve, and that a great many believers have never definitely handed themselves over at all.

Neither yield ye your members as instruments of unrighteousness unto sin: but yield yourselves unto God.

ROMANS 6:13

Whether that yielding is a crisis or the first of ten thousand small consecrations, it has to happen.

There is a diagnostic in this that anyone can apply.

Take the fault you have fought longest — the temper, the tongue, the appetite, the fear. Ask honestly what method you have been using. If the answer is resolution, monitoring and effort, you have been trying to produce what only Christ can be in you.

That is not an argument for doing nothing. It is an argument for doing something different.

What it does not mean

Simpson was careful to fence this doctrine, because the language of holiness teaching has been used to claim things Scripture does not.

It does not mean sinless perfection. Simpson denied that any believer arrives at a state in which sin is impossible or temptation has no force. He held that the capacity for sin remains, that the believer stands only by continuing dependence, and that anyone who claims otherwise is contradicting the apostle.

If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us.

1 JOHN 1:8

It does not mean the eradication of the old nature. What Simpson taught was displacement rather than removal — the indwelling Christ occupying and governing what remains, moment by moment, in the way a stream keeps a channel clean by continuing to flow rather than by the channel being altered.

And it does not mean the end of growth. The believer who has made the fullest consecration he knows how to make has surrendered only what he could see at the time. Ten years later God will show him territory he did not know existed, and the same handing over will be required again on new ground.

But the path of the just is as the shining light, that shineth more and more unto the perfect day.

PROVERBS 4:18

The image is of increasing light, not of arrival. Simpson used it to protect believers from two errors at once: the presumption that says the matter is settled and needs no further attention, and the despair that says nothing has happened because everything has not.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Identify the sin you have fought longest by willpower. Bring it to Christ as something to receive victory in rather than achieve.
2. Make a definite transaction if you never have: hand yourself over, in words, on a date, and tell someone.
3. Examine whose energy your service runs on. Exhaustion and resentment are usually the first symptoms of the wrong answer.
4. Practise abiding concretely: a fixed daily time of conscious dependence before the day's work rather than after it.
5. Hold this doctrine graciously. Sincere believers differ about the crisis; none differ about the necessity of holiness.

A PRAYER

*Lord Jesus, I have been trying to produce a holiness that only You can be in me.
I have resolved and failed, resolved and failed, and called the cycle the Christian life.
I am tired of it, and I think that is Your mercy.
I hand myself over — not a portion, and not on conditions. Be my sanctification as truly as You are my righteousness.
Keep me abiding. Let the fruit be Yours, and let me stop straining to grow what only sap can produce. Amen.*

Christ Our Healer

Is any sick among you? let him call for the elders of the church; and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord.

JAMES 5:14

This is the most contested wheel of Simpson's chariot, and it must be handled with more care than any other chapter in this book. Please read the cautions at the end. They are not an afterthought; they are part of the teaching.

The pine woods at Old Orchard

Simpson had been an invalid for much of his adult life. He suffered from a heart condition, had collapsed more than once from overwork, and carried a bottle of medicine with him for the attacks that came when he climbed a flight of stairs. A physician in New York had told him he had about three months.

In the summer of 1881, resting at the conference grounds at Old Orchard Beach in Maine, he heard Dr Charles Cullis teach on divine healing. He was less moved by the arguments than by the testimonies of people who had been healed.

He went away and studied his New Testament on the subject for himself, and became convinced. On a Friday afternoon in August he walked alone into the pine woods and made a threefold pledge: that he accepted the Bible's teaching that Jesus heals the body; that he took Christ then and there as his physical life for every need of his body until his life-work was finished; and that he would use the strength given him for the glory of God and the service of others.

The next day he climbed a mountain of three thousand feet. Shortly afterwards he prayed for his daughter Margaret, gravely ill with diphtheria — the disease that had killed his young son Melville a decade before — and she recovered. He lived thirty-eight more years himself, and worked at a pace that exhausted much younger men.

What he taught

Simpson set out his position in *The Gospel of Healing* (1885), and its core is a claim about the atonement.

Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows ...he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed.

ISAIAH 53:4–5

Matthew quotes the first half of that passage and applies it explicitly to Christ's healing ministry (Matthew 8:16–17). From this Simpson argued that Christ bore our sicknesses as truly as our sins, and that healing for the body therefore belongs within the provision of the cross rather than outside it.

He was careful about what this did not mean. He did not teach that the body is already redeemed — he held firmly that full physical redemption awaits the resurrection. What he claimed was that a measure of resurrection life is available now, to be drawn upon by faith, as strength for the body while the Lord's work for that person remains unfinished. His own phrasing was that he took Christ as his physical life *until all my life-work is done* — a qualification that is almost always omitted when he is quoted.

He also insisted the doctrine be kept in proportion. When the healing evangelist John Alexander Dowie invited him to devote himself to a nationwide healing campaign, Simpson answered that he had four wheels on his chariot and could not neglect three to concentrate on one. He never allowed healing to become the message.

What is genuinely biblical here

Several things in Simpson's emphasis are plainly scriptural, and churches that have reacted against the excesses have often lost them.

God heals, and He heals today. Nothing in Scripture retires the practice.

The church is instructed to pray for the sick, and specifically to anoint them with oil through its elders. James 5 is a standing command that a great many congregations simply ignore.

And the prayer of faith shall save the sick, and the Lord shall raise him up.

JAMES 5:15

The body matters to God. He made it, Christ took one, and it will be raised. A spirituality that treats the body as irrelevant is closer to ancient paganism than to Scripture.

And Christ's compassion for the sick is one of the most conspicuous features of the Gospels. He was repeatedly *moved with compassion* before He healed anybody.

Where it must be qualified

Now the necessary corrections, and they must be stated without softening, because people have been badly hurt here.

Scripture does not promise healing in every case. The New Testament records faithful believers who were not healed. Paul left Trophimus sick at Miletus (2 Timothy 4:20). Epaphroditus was ill to the point of death (Philippians 2:27). Timothy had a recurring stom-

ach complaint, and Paul's counsel was not a rebuke about faith but a practical remedy (1 Timothy 5:23). And Paul himself asked three times for the removal of his thorn and was refused.

And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness.

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

That is God declining to heal an apostle, and calling the refusal grace. Any doctrine that cannot accommodate this verse has a defect.

The sick must never be blamed. The teaching that continued illness proves deficient faith is cruel, and it is the error God rebuked in the book of Job. It adds guilt to suffering and drives the afflicted away from the church precisely when they need it. If you have been told your illness is your fault, that was not the mind of Christ toward you.

Medicine is not unbelief. Luke, who travelled with Paul, is called the beloved physician. The Samaritan poured oil and wine into wounds. Isaiah applied a poultice of figs to Hezekiah's boil in the same episode in which God miraculously extended his life. Scripture nowhere treats treatment and trust as rivals.

Simpson's own practice went further than this. After 1881 he set aside medical means entirely for himself and taught others to do the same, and some who followed him died of conditions that could have been treated. This is the point at which he must be respectfully declined. **Nothing in this chapter should lead any reader to refuse, delay or discontinue medical care. Pray, and see your physician.**

And everyone dies. Simpson grew frail, lost his memory, and died at seventy-five. That is not a failure of his doctrine; it is the human condition. The final healing is not in this life.

Even we ourselves groan within ourselves, waiting for the adoption, to wit, the redemption of our body.

ROMANS 8:23

Held with those corrections, the substance remains and it is worth recovering. Pray boldly for the sick. Obey James 5. Expect God to act, and leave the outcome with Him. And when He does not heal, do not conclude that He has not answered — Paul did not.

How to pray for the sick

A practical note, since the doctrine can leave believers unsure what to actually say at a bedside.

Pray boldly. Ask plainly for healing, without hedging every sentence into meaninglessness. The Lord invited direct requests, and the sick person is generally helped by hearing someone ask God for the thing they want.

Pray submissively. The pattern is in Gethsemane, where the Son of God asked for the cup to pass and added a clause.

Nevertheless not as I will, but as thou wilt.

MATTHEW 26:39

That clause is not weak faith. It is the faith of the One who had more of it than anybody, and it belongs in our praying for the same reason it belonged in His.

Promise nothing. Do not tell a sick person that God will certainly heal them in this life. You do not know, and if you are wrong they must bear both the illness and the collapse of what they were told.

Stay. The most valuable thing most of us can offer is not a prayer formula but persistence — continuing to visit when the novelty has worn off and the condition has not improved. Job's friends were at their best in the seven days they sat and said nothing.

And pray for more than the body. Ask for endurance, for peace, for the absence of bitterness, for the person's family. These prayers are always according to God's will, and they are always answered.

Casting all your care upon him; for he careth for you.

1 PETER 5:7

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Pray specifically and expectantly for someone who is ill this week, without promising them an outcome God has not promised.
2. If your church never practises James 5:14, ask your leaders why.
3. If you have been made to feel that your illness is a verdict on your faith, reject that. It is not the teaching of Scripture.
4. Take your medicine and keep your appointments. Trust and treatment are not rivals.
5. Sit with 2 Corinthians 12:9 until you can say it about the thing God has not removed from you.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You healed the sick because You were moved with compassion, and You are unchanged.

Teach me to pray boldly for the suffering, without pretending to know what You have not told me.

Where You heal, let me give You the glory. Where You do not, let me hear You say that Your grace is sufficient, and believe it.

And guard me from ever adding to another's burden by suggesting that their sickness is their own fault. Amen.

Christ Our Coming King

This same Jesus, which is taken up from you into heaven, shall so come in like manner as ye have seen him go into heaven.

ACTS 1:11

The fourth wheel was, for Simpson, not a speculative appendix but the engine of everything practical he did. He built a training school, founded a missionary society and drove himself into repeated exhaustion because he believed the King was coming and there was work to finish first.

A personal, visible return

His position was straightforward and he defended it against the alternatives current in his day.

The return of Christ is personal — *this same Jesus*, not a principle, an influence, or the gradual improvement of society. It is visible. And it is an event, not a process.

Behold, he cometh with clouds; and every eye shall see him.

REVELATION 1:7

For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout ...and the dead in Christ shall rise first.

1 THESSALONIANS 4:16

Simpson held the premillennial view — that Christ returns before the promised age of righteousness, rather than at the end of a period of gradual Christian progress. This mattered to him practically. The optimistic alternative popular in his generation held that the world was steadily improving and the kingdom was arriving through civilisation and reform. Simpson thought that view drained the urgency out of missions, and the twentieth century did not treat it kindly.

Christians differ on the details of the timing, and have since the earliest centuries. What the New Testament asserts without ambiguity is the fact.

Why it is called a blessed hope

Looking for that blessed hope, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Saviour Jesus Christ.

TITUS 2:13

Simpson dwelt on the adjective. The return of Christ is not, for the believer, primarily a terror. It is the moment the whole story has been

travelling towards: the end of separation, the vindication of everything endured, and the sight of the One we have loved without seeing.

Whom having not seen, ye love ...yet believing, ye rejoice with joy unspeakable and full of glory.

1 PETER 1:8

He noticed how the New Testament actually deploys this doctrine. It is used to comfort the bereaved, to steady the persecuted, to encourage the labouring, and to sober the careless. It is almost never used to satisfy curiosity.

What the hope produces

Three effects, each with a text.

Purity. The expectation of seeing Him has a cleansing force that mere rules do not.

And every man that hath this hope in him purifieth himself, even as he is pure.

1 JOHN 3:3

Watchfulness. Not calculation — watchfulness. The believer lives as a servant whose master may return at any hour, which is a different posture from one who has worked out the schedule.

Watch therefore: for ye know not what hour your Lord doth come.

MATTHEW 24:42

Urgency in mission. This is the link that governed Simpson's life, and it comes from the Lord's own words.

And this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; and then shall the end come.

MATTHEW 24:14

Simpson read that as a task with a stated relation to the return, and it made him incapable of leaving the unreached alone. Every institution he founded was built to get workers to places where Christ had not been named.

Where he was mistaken

Honesty requires a note.

Simpson and many of his contemporaries expected that the gospel might reach every nation within their own generation, and that the Lord would then return. That expectation was not fulfilled, and similar expectations have failed in every century since the first.

He generally avoided setting dates, and he was more restrained than many around him. But the flavour of imminence in his writing sometimes shades into calculation, and the reader should hold that lightly. The Lord Himself declined to supply the information.

And he said unto them, It is not for you to know the times or the seasons, which the Father hath put in his own power. But ye shall receive power ...and ye shall be witnesses unto me.

ACTS 1:7-8

Notice how the verse continues. The refusal of the timetable is immediately followed by the commission. That is exactly the right ordering, and it preserves everything valuable in Simpson's urgency while removing what was mistaken in it.

The practical question is not when He is coming. It is whether you would be glad to be found doing what you are doing when He does.

A doctrine for the grieving

It is worth noticing the setting in which the New Testament's fullest teaching on the return of Christ appears, because it is not a prophecy conference.

Paul is writing to a young church that has buried some of its members and is distressed about them. The question is not chronology. It is whether their dead have missed something.

But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope.

1 THESSALONIANS 4:13

Paul then gives the great passage about the Lord descending with a shout, the dead in Christ rising first, and the living being caught up together with them. And he closes not with an exhortation to watch the signs but with an instruction about pastoral care.

Wherefore comfort one another with these words.

1 THESSALONIANS 4:18

Simpson kept this use of the doctrine prominent, and it is a good test of whether we are handling it as Scripture does. A believer whose interest in the second coming runs entirely to charts and current events has drifted from the apostolic pattern. A believer who can sit with a grieving friend and make the return of Christ a genuine consolation is using it exactly as Paul did.

Note also the phrase *together with them*. The reunion is part of the hope. The Christian's expectation is not merely that he will see Christ, but that the separations death has caused are temporary.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask whether the return of Christ functions in your life as a doctrine you affirm or a hope you actually anticipate.

2. Apply 1 John 3:3 concretely: name one thing you would want dealt with before He appears, and deal with it.
3. Stop calculating and start watching. If you follow prophetic speculation, consider how much of that time could go to intercession instead.
4. Use this hope the way the New Testament does — to comfort someone bereaved, or to steady someone under pressure.
5. Consider what you are doing that will matter on that day, and do more of it.

A PRAYER

*Lord Jesus, You are coming, and I have arranged my life as though You were not.
Forgive the drowsiness that treats Your return as a doctrine rather than a hope.
Make me watchful without making me speculative.
Purify me. Let the thought of seeing You do what rules have never done in me.
And let me be found at work — among the people You died for, in the places where
You are not yet named — when You come. Amen.*

The Self Life and the Christ Life

I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me.

GALATIANS 2:20

One of Simpson's most searching books carries the title *The Self Life and the Christ Life*, and its argument is that the Christian's fundamental problem is not his sins but his self.

The root beneath the branches

Most of us deal with our Christian lives at the level of particular faults. We notice a bad temper, a sharp tongue, a habit of exaggeration, and we address each as it appears — pruning branches, one at a time, for decades.

Simpson's contention is that the branches keep growing because the root is untouched. Beneath the individual sins lies a single organising principle: the self at the centre, arranging everything around its own comfort, reputation and will.

He was fond of listing the forms it takes, and the list is uncomfortable reading because it catches almost everyone somewhere. Self-will, which must have its own way. Self-love, which cannot be neglected without pain. Self-confidence, which undertakes God's work in its own strength. Self-consciousness, which is paralysed by what others think. Self-pity, which nurses its grievances. Self-seeking, self-defence, self-indulgence, self-justification. And most elusive of all, self-righteousness — the self admiring its own progress in crucifying itself.

And he said to them all, If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me.

LUKE 9:23

Simpson pointed out that the Lord does not say deny yourself *things*. He says deny *yourself* — disown the self as the governing principle. The denial of things is easy by comparison, and can be performed with considerable self-satisfaction.

Not suppression, but exchange

Here Simpson parts company with mere asceticism, and the distinction is the heart of his teaching.

You cannot remove the self by attacking it. Every attempt produces a new and subtler form of the same thing, because the one doing the

attacking is the self. A man may starve his body, renounce his ambitions and cultivate a reputation for humility, and be more thoroughly self-occupied at the end than at the beginning.

The remedy is not subtraction but substitution. The self life is displaced by the Christ life, as darkness is displaced by light rather than removed by effort.

He must increase, but I must decrease.

JOHN 3:30

Simpson insisted on the order in that verse. The increase comes first, and the decrease follows from it. We do not diminish ourselves in order to make room for Christ; we receive Christ, and our own importance quietly collapses because something larger has arrived.

The daily cross

Note the word *daily* in Luke 9:23. Simpson took it seriously, and it guards his teaching against the misuse that has attended every doctrine of surrender.

The reckoning of Romans 6 is settled once. Its application is renewed every morning, and generally in circumstances we did not choose. The cross is presented to us not as an abstraction but as an interruption, a slight, an inconvenience, a person who will not do what we want.

For we which live are always delivered unto death for Jesus' sake, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our mortal flesh.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:11

The clause at the end is the point. The dying is never an end in itself. It is always in order that something else may appear.

Personality is not the enemy

A caution that Simpson supplied himself, and that his followers sometimes lost.

The self life is not the same as personality, temperament or natural ability. God made those and intends to use them. The goal is not a colourless Christian — Simpson himself remained recognisably a driven, visionary, organising Scotsman to the end of his days, and the movement he built could not have existed otherwise.

What goes to the cross is the self as *centre*, not the self as *creature*. Peter after Pentecost is still impetuous Peter; the impetuosity now serves Christ instead of Peter.

For to me to live is Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 1:21

There is a test in this that requires no theology to apply.

Watch what happens in you the next time you are contradicted, overlooked, or corrected in front of others. Whatever rises in that moment, unbidden, before you have time to arrange your face — that is the thing this chapter is about.

Self in the Lord's work

The subtlest form of the self life, Simpson observed, does not appear in worldly pursuits at all. It appears in ministry, where it is nearly invisible because everything about it looks like devotion.

Self can want a platform and call it a burden for souls. It can resent a colleague's success and call it concern for sound doctrine. It can labour to exhaustion and call it consecration when the real engine is the need to be needed. It can defend its position tenaciously and call it contending for the faith.

The New Testament knows this problem and names names.

I wrote unto the church: but Diotrephes, who loveth to have the preeminence among them, receiveth us not.

3 JOHN 9

Paul, remarkably, was able to distinguish between the message and the motive of those who preached it, and to rejoice even where the motive was bad.

Some indeed preach Christ even of envy and strife ...What then? notwithstanding, every way, whether in pretence, or in truth, Christ is preached; and I therein do rejoice.

PHILIPPIANS 1:15, 18

Simpson drew two things from this. First, that God is able to use a ministry in which self is heavily involved, which should relieve us of the anxiety that nothing will be blessed until our motives are pure — they never will be entirely. And second, that this must never become an excuse for leaving the motives unexamined.

The practical test he suggested is uncomfortable and quick. How do you feel when someone else is used to do the thing you wanted to do? The answer arrives before you can arrange it, and it is generally accurate.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Go through Simpson's list — self-will, self-pity, self-defence, self-seeking — and name the one that fits you most exactly.
2. Stop attacking the self directly. Give the same energy to receiving Christ, and watch what happens to the other.

3. Take the next contradiction or slight as the day's cross rather than as an obstacle to your spiritual life. It is the material.
4. When you are misunderstood this week, decline to defend yourself once, and observe what rises.
5. Distinguish self from personality. Do not seek to be less yourself; seek to be less your own centre.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, I have been trimming branches for years, and the root is untouched.

I see it now: not merely my sins, but myself — at the centre, arranging everything, wanting my own way and calling it conviction.

I cannot crucify myself; every attempt has made me proud of the attempt. So come and increase, and let me decrease as a consequence rather than an achievement.

Give me today's cross, and let me take it without complaint — that the life of Jesus might be seen in me. Amen.

Wholly Sanctified

And the very God of peace sanctify you wholly; and I pray God your whole spirit and soul and body be preserved blameless unto the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:23

Simpson wrote a small book on this single verse, and the title he gave it is the word he would not let go of: *Wholly Sanctified*.

The emphasis falls on the adverb. Paul does not pray that the Thessalonians be partly sanctified, or sanctified in their religious department. He prays for the whole person, and then names the parts in case anyone should misunderstand: spirit, and soul, and body.

What the word means

Simpson began where the Old Testament begins, because the vocabulary comes from there.

To sanctify is to set apart. When the vessels of the tabernacle were sanctified they were not morally improved — a bowl has no morals. They were transferred from ordinary use to God's use. That is the root idea, and it is the reason sanctification is not primarily about the removal of faults.

If a man therefore purge himself from these, he shall be a vessel unto honour, sanctified, and meet for the master's use, and prepared unto every good work.

2 TIMOTHY 2:21

There are two movements in it, and Simpson insisted on both.

There is separation *from* — the withdrawal of the vessel from common service. And there is consecration *to* — its dedication to the owner who will now use it as He pleases.

A great deal of holiness teaching stops at the first, and produces Christians whose religion is chiefly a list of things they do not do. Separation without consecration yields an empty vessel, scrupulously clean and used for nothing. The point of taking the bowl off the common shelf is to put it on the altar.

Spirit, soul and body

Paul's threefold naming gave Simpson his structure, and he applied it concretely.

The **spirit** is sanctified when a man's deepest life is turned Godward — when his communion, his conscience and his intuitive sense of God's

will are governed by the Holy Spirit rather than by his own preferences.

The **soul** is sanctified when the mind, the emotions and the will come under Christ. Simpson gave particular attention to this middle region, because it is where most Christians live and where most of the trouble is. A sanctified mind is not merely a mind that thinks correct doctrine; it is one whose habitual imagination has been cleansed. Sanctified emotions are not suppressed emotions; they are affections attached to what deserves them. A sanctified will is not a broken will but a surrendered one.

And be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind.

ROMANS 12:2

The **body** is sanctified when its members are placed at God's disposal — the eyes, the tongue, the appetite, the hands, the hours. Simpson took this literally and unsentimentally, and it is the point at which his teaching on holiness runs directly into his teaching on healing: the body is not a regrettable container for the soul but a temple bought at a price.

What? know ye not that your body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you ...ye are not your own? For ye are bought with a price: therefore glorify God in your body.

1 CORINTHIANS 6:19–20

The One who does it

Now the sentence that Simpson regarded as the whole security of the doctrine, and which is almost always left off when the verse is quoted.

Faithful is he that calleth you, who also will do it.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:24

Paul does not command the Thessalonians to sanctify themselves wholly. He prays that God will do it, and then adds that God is faithful and will.

This is the guard against the two diseases of holiness teaching. It prevents despair, because the outcome does not rest on the believer's capacity. And it prevents pride, because a work God performs leaves nobody anything to boast about.

Simpson's counsel was accordingly simple. Present the vessel; God will fill and use it. Our part is the handing over; His part is everything that follows.

I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service.

ROMANS 12:1

Wholly, and therefore now

One further observation, and it is the practical sting of the chapter.

The word *wholly* exposes the arrangement most of us actually operate. We have consecrated regions. There is a part of life we have handed over — usually the explicitly religious part — and there are territories that have never come up in prayer at all: how money is spent, how a spouse is spoken to, what is watched alone, what is done with anger, how a business treats those who cannot complain.

Simpson's question was not whether you have surrendered, but whether there is anything you have quietly kept off the list. And he noticed that most believers can name it within a few seconds of being asked, which suggests they have known about it for some time.

There is a mercy hidden in the word *preserved* in this verse, which Simpson pointed out and which is easily missed.

Paul does not merely ask that the Thessalonians be sanctified; he asks that they be *preserved* blameless until the coming of Christ. The One who sets the vessel apart also keeps it. That is a longer commitment than any of us would make about ourselves, and it is offered by Someone who does not tire.

Keeping the surrender

A consecration once made does not stay made without attention, and Simpson was realistic about the leakage.

The New Testament image he used was the altar. The sacrifice is laid on it in a definite act — but Paul's phrase is a *living* sacrifice, and a living sacrifice can get down. Nothing holds it there but its own continuing consent.

If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me.

LUKE 9:23

Daily. The word is in the text, and Simpson would not let it be softened into a general disposition. The handing over is renewed each morning, usually before anything has happened to make it feel necessary.

He recommended a specific practice, and it is worth adopting because it takes about ninety seconds. On waking, before the day's demands arrive, present the day: the hours, the people, the interruptions not yet known, the temper not yet tested. Not a long devotion — a definite transfer of ownership, made in words, before the ownership is contested.

O God, thou art my God; early will I seek thee.

PSALM 63:1

The reason for doing this early is practical. By ten o'clock the day has taken shape, several small decisions have been made on autopilot, and the surrender is now being attempted against resistance rather than in advance of it.

Simpson's observation was that most believers who lose ground do not lose it in a crisis. They lose it in the accumulation of mornings on which the transfer was simply not made.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Name the territory you have never brought into prayer. You will know it immediately. Bring it now.
2. Check whether your holiness is chiefly separation from things. If the vessel is clean and unused, that is only half the doctrine.
3. Take Paul's three areas in turn and name one specific thing in each — spirit, soul, body — that needs to be handed over.
4. Rest on 1 Thessalonians 5:24. Where you have despaired of change, remind God of His own promise to do it.
5. Present the vessel again this morning, and then get on with the day instead of monitoring yourself.

A PRAYER

God of peace, sanctify me wholly — not the religious part, not the part that shows, but all of it.

Take my spirit, and make my communion with You real. Take my soul — my mind with its wandering, my feelings with their disorder, my will with its insistence. Take my body, my eyes and tongue and appetite and hours.

There is one place I have kept back, and You know what it is. I bring it now.

Faithful is He who calls me, who also will do it. I rest on that, because I have proved I cannot do it myself. Amen.

The Land of Promise

So we see that they could not enter in because of unbelief.

HEBREWS 3:19

Simpson's favourite way of describing the Christian life was a map, and the map came from the book of Joshua.

Israel's history divides into three: Egypt, the wilderness, and Canaan. And he held — following a reading with a long pedigree in Puritan and Keswick teaching — that these correspond to three conditions in which people may be found.

Three places

Egypt is bondage. A person in Egypt is not God's, has not been redeemed, and is a slave whether or not he knows it.

The wilderness is the condition Simpson was most concerned about. Here are people who have genuinely left Egypt — the blood has been applied, the sea has been crossed, they belong to God — and who are going in circles. They are saved and defeated. They have real experience of God's provision and no possession of anything. They live on manna, complain a good deal, and remember Egypt with a fondness that horrifies them.

Canaan is the land of promise: not comfort, but possession.

Now the crucial point, and Simpson made it repeatedly because the mistake is so common. Canaan is not heaven.

We sing about crossing Jordan as a figure for dying, and it makes for good hymns, but it will not survive examination. There are giants in Canaan. There are walled cities, unconquered territory, defeats like Ai, and forty years of warfare. Nobody fights battles in heaven. Canaan is a picture of the Christian life as God intends it now — a life of rest and conflict at once, in which the believer possesses what has been given him and has to take ground to do it.

Every place that the sole of your foot shall tread upon, that have I given unto you.

JOSHUA 1:3

Note the tense. *Have I given*. The land is already theirs by grant; they enter into what is already legally theirs.

Why a generation did not enter

The wilderness generation stood at the border at Kadesh-barnea and did not go in. Simpson dwelt on the reason, because Scripture states it

plainly and it is not what we would guess.

They did not fail through weakness, or through sin in the ordinary sense, or because the giants were genuinely too large. They failed through unbelief. Ten of the twelve spies reported accurately about the giants and inaccurately about God.

And they brought up an evil report of the land ...and we were in our own sight as grasshoppers, and so we were in their sight.

NUMBERS 13:32–33

So we see that they could not enter in because of unbelief.

HEBREWS 3:19

The writer to the Hebrews applies this directly to Christians, which is what licenses the whole comparison. He is not making a devotional analogy; he is arguing that the same danger stands over the church.

There remaineth therefore a rest to the people of God ...Let us labour therefore to enter into that rest, lest any man fall after the same example of unbelief.

HEBREWS 4:9, 11

Crossing Jordan

Between the wilderness and the land lies a river, and Simpson made much of the manner of the crossing.

The Red Sea is deliverance *from* Egypt — redemption, the picture of the cross applied to our guilt. Jordan is different. It is entered by the ark going first into the water, and it stands, in this reading, for the believer's identification with Christ in death and resurrection — the end of the old self-directed life and the beginning of a life lived from another source.

Likewise reckon ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin, but alive unto God through Jesus Christ our Lord.

ROMANS 6:11

On the far bank the manna ceased and they ate the old corn of the land. Simpson took that as a picture of the change from a life of daily emergency supply to a life of settled possession.

A caution about typology

Honesty requires a note here.

This kind of reading can be pressed too far. The Old Testament narrative was not written as an allegory of individual spiritual experience, and interpreters who treat every detail as a code have often ended up saying whatever they wished. The disciplined approach is to follow the New Testament's own use: Hebrews 3 and 4 authorise the comparison between the wilderness generation and the church, and 1 Corinthians 10 does the same. Beyond what Scripture itself draws out, hold loosely.

Some careful Christians also object that this scheme creates two classes of believer — the wilderness sort and the Canaan sort — in a way the New Testament does not. The objection has force, and it should be weighed.

What survives every qualification is the substance: it is entirely possible to be genuinely redeemed and to spend decades possessing almost nothing of what God has given, and the reason is not weakness but unbelief.

The border is not crossed by trying harder in the wilderness. Israel did not enter Canaan by improving its wilderness performance. It entered by going in.

Rest and conflict together

The most common misunderstanding of this teaching is that the land of promise means the end of struggle. It does not, and Joshua makes that unmistakable.

Canaan contained walled cities, iron chariots, a coalition of hostile kings and a defeat at Ai brought about by one man's concealed sin. The conquest took years. Some ground was never taken at all, because certain tribes could not be bothered to finish.

So the life Simpson was describing is not one of ease. It is a life in which rest and conflict exist together — rest as the settled condition of the heart, and conflict as the ordinary experience of the day. The New Testament says the same thing about the believer's position.

And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus.

EPHESIANS 2:6

For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers.

EPHESIANS 6:12

Seated, and wrestling — in the same letter, to the same people. Simpson took that as the exact description of Canaan: the ground is given, and it must still be taken.

There is a warning attached, and it comes from the tribes who stopped early. The book of Judges opens with a list of the places that were never cleared, and the rest of the book is the consequence. Unfinished conquest does not stay neutral — what is left becomes, in the phrase of the text, thorns in the sides of God's people.

The application is straightforward and searching. The area of your life you have decided not to contest will not remain a quiet exception. It will become the source of your trouble in ten years.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Locate yourself honestly on the map. Egypt, wilderness, or land?
2. If you are circling, ask what report you have been believing about the giants — and whether it was accurate about them and inaccurate about God.
3. Identify one promise of God you have never actually acted on. Put your foot on that ground this week.
4. Notice the pull back to Egypt. What do you find yourself remembering fondly that God brought you out of?
5. Stop waiting to feel ready. Israel never felt ready; the ones who went in were not braver, only more convinced about God.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have been out of Egypt for years and I have possessed very little.

I have circled the same ground, complained about the same things, and called it the Christian life. I have believed accurate reports about the giants and false reports about You.

You have given me the land. Teach me to put my foot on it.

Take me across Jordan — through the death and resurrection of Your Son — into what You have already granted, and let me stop living on emergency rations in sight of Your abundance. Amen.

The Indwelling Spirit

Even the Spirit of truth ...for he dwelleth with you, and shall be in you.

JOHN 14:17

Simpson wrote more on the Holy Spirit than on any other subject except Christ Himself, and his treatment has a particular character that distinguishes it from much that has been written since.

A Person, not a power

His first insistence was elementary and constantly neglected: the Holy Spirit is a Person.

The pronouns in the upper room discourse are personal — *he*, not *it* — and the activities ascribed to Him are the activities of a person. He teaches, guides, reminds, convinces, forbids, appoints, intercedes. He can be grieved, which no force can be. He can be lied to, resisted and quenched.

And grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption.

EPHESIANS 4:30

Simpson pressed the practical consequence hard. If the Spirit is a power, the question is how to get more of Him and how to use Him. If He is a Person, those questions are impertinent. You do not use a person. The question becomes how not to grieve Him, and how much of you He has.

He put it in a form that has been repeated ever since: the issue is not whether you have the Holy Spirit but whether the Holy Spirit has you.

With you, and in you

The verse at the head of this chapter contains a distinction that Simpson regarded as the hinge of the whole subject.

He dwelleth with you, and shall be in you. Before Pentecost the Spirit was *with* the disciples — accompanying, empowering, working alongside. After Pentecost He would be *in* them.

That change is the great privilege of the present age. The Old Testament records the Spirit coming upon particular people for particular tasks and departing again. The New Testament describes something unprecedented: permanent residence in ordinary believers.

Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?

1 CORINTHIANS 3:16

Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his.

ROMANS 8:9

Simpson was careful with that last verse, because it settles a question people still get wrong. The indwelling Spirit is not the possession of an advanced class of Christian. Every believer has Him; nobody is a believer without Him. Whatever the fullness of the Spirit means — and the next chapter takes that up — it cannot mean receiving a Spirit one previously lacked.

His work is to glorify Christ

Here is the feature that most distinguishes Simpson's teaching, and it is the best safeguard against the excesses that have attended this doctrine.

He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you.

JOHN 16:14

The Holy Spirit's stated purpose is not to draw attention to Himself. It is to make Christ real. He is, as Simpson liked to say, the executive of the Godhead in this age, whose whole business is to take what belongs to Jesus and make it actual in believers.

This yields a test that can be applied to any teaching, meeting or movement claiming the Spirit's authority. Does it leave people occupied with the Spirit and His manifestations, or occupied with Christ? A ministry genuinely full of the Holy Spirit will tend to talk about Jesus, because that is what the Spirit does.

It also explains why Simpson's Fourfold Gospel has no separate wheel for the Holy Spirit, which puzzles some readers. It is not an omission. In his thinking the Spirit is the one who administers all four — the agent by whom Christ is Saviour, Sanctifier, Healer and Coming King within us.

The Spirit and the ordinary

One further note, because Simpson's own life illustrates it.

We associate the Spirit's work with the extraordinary, and Scripture does record extraordinary things. But the great bulk of what the New Testament attributes to Him is unspectacular: assurance that we are God's children, help in prayer when we do not know what to ask, the slow production of character, the ability to call God Father and mean it.

The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God.

ROMANS 8:16

Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought.

ROMANS 8:26

A believer who has never had a dramatic experience and who prays, endures, loves awkward people and grows slowly kinder is exhibiting the work of the Holy Spirit as certainly as anyone.

The question to carry out of this chapter is not how to obtain more of the Spirit. It is how much of you He has, and where you have been grieving Him — a question a Person can be asked directly.

How He leads

If the Spirit indwells the believer, how does His guidance actually arrive? Simpson's answer was deliberately unspectacular.

For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God.

ROMANS 8:14

He identified several ordinary means, and insisted they normally agree.

The **Word**, which is the primary and governing means. Most of what God wants from a believer on any given day is already written, and no further guidance is required to begin obeying it.

The **inward witness** — a settled sense of peace about a course, or an inward check against it. Simpson took this seriously without making it decisive on its own.

And let the peace of God rule in your hearts.

COLOSSIANS 3:15

Circumstances, which God arranges, and **counsel**, which He supplies through mature believers who know us and are not impressed by us.

His rule of thumb was that these ordinarily converge, and that a believer should be slow to act on one against the others. An impression that contradicts Scripture is not the Spirit, whatever it feels like. An open door that requires disobedience is not from God, however convenient.

He was equally firm about the danger. Believers who elevate impressions to the level of revelation become unteachable, since any objection can be answered by appeal to a private message no one else can examine. Simpson had watched this wreck people, and he never allowed the inward sense to be treated as an authority in its own right.

The Spirit who speaks within is the same Spirit who wrote the Word, and He does not contradict Himself.

1. Stop asking for more of the Spirit and start asking what part of you He does not yet have.
2. Identify one thing you know grieves Him. Deal with that before seeking any further experience.
3. Apply the John 16:14 test to whatever teaching you are under: does it leave you occupied with Christ?
4. Thank God for the unspectacular evidences — assurance, help in prayer, slow growth in kindness. These are His work.
5. Speak to the Spirit as a Person this week, not as a resource.

A PRAYER

Holy Spirit, I have treated You as a power to be obtained rather than a Person to be obeyed. Forgive me.

You dwell in me. I do not need to fetch You from a distance or persuade You to come. The question is how much of me You have, and I think we both know the answer.

Show me where I am grieving You, and give me no rest about it.

And do in me what You came to do: take the things of Christ and make them real, until I am occupied with Him and not with my own experience. Amen.

Filled with the Spirit

And be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess; but be filled with the Spirit.

EPHESIANS 5:18

If every believer has the Holy Spirit, what is the fullness, and why does Paul have to command it?

Simpson's answer began with the grammar. The verb in Ephesians 5:18 is an imperative, which means the fullness is not automatic; and it is continuous, which means it is not a single event to be obtained and filed away. Paul is commanding a state to be maintained.

Full of what is already there

His illustration was the difference between a vessel that contains water and one that is full of it.

Every believer has the Spirit; the question is displacement. A jar with an inch of water in it and a great deal of air is not empty — but it is not full either. The filling of the Spirit is not the arrival of more Spirit from outside. It is the Spirit occupying more of the person.

This explains the terms of the contrast Paul chose. A man under the influence of drink is controlled by it: his speech, his judgment and his behaviour are governed by something other than himself. Paul's point is not about the pleasure but about the control. To be filled with the Spirit is to be under His government at that level.

And when they had prayed, the place was shaken where they were assembled together; and they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and they spake the word of God with boldness.

ACTS 4:31

Simpson noted that the people filled in Acts 4 include several who had already been filled in Acts 2. The fullness is repeatable, which is fatal to any scheme that treats it as a once-for-all attainment.

The conditions

Simpson set out what a believer may do, and was careful that none of it becomes a technique for extracting something from God.

Emptying. A vessel already full of something else cannot be filled. The practical work here is honest inventory: what occupies the space — ambition, resentment, a hidden appetite, self-pity?

Asking. The promise is explicit and the terms are generous.

If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children: how much more shall your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to them that ask him?

LUKE 11:13

Obeying. The Spirit is given to the obedient, not to the impressive.

And so is also the Holy Ghost, whom God hath given to them that obey him.

ACTS 5:32

Taking by faith. Here Simpson applied his general principle: what God promises is received by faith, not produced by feeling. A believer who has emptied, asked and obeyed may take the fullness on the strength of the promise and go about his business, whether or not anything registers emotionally.

The question of tongues

This chapter cannot avoid the controversy that broke over Simpson's movement after 1906, and his handling of it is one of the more instructive episodes in his life.

The Pentecostal revival spread rapidly through the constituencies nearest to his own, and many Alliance people were caught up in it. The question pressed on him was whether speaking in tongues is the necessary evidence that a believer has been baptised or filled with the Spirit.

Simpson did not answer from the sidelines. He wanted everything God had. In August 1907 he returned to the same pine woods at Old Orchard where he had been healed, and asked God for a fuller baptism of the Spirit with all His gifts and graces. He did not speak in tongues, then or afterwards.

His conclusion was threefold. Tongues is a genuine gift of the Spirit, not to be despised or forbidden. It is not the necessary evidence of the Spirit's fullness, since Scripture nowhere makes it the test and Paul asks plainly whether all speak with tongues, expecting the answer no (1 Corinthians 12:30). And believers should not make it the object of pursuit, because the Spirit distributes gifts as He wills rather than as we select.

But all these worketh that one and the selfsame Spirit, dividing to every man severally as he will.

1 CORINTHIANS 12:11

The policy he settled on has marked his movement ever since, and it is expressed in four words: *seek not, forbid not*.

It cost him. He lost people who wanted more and people who wanted the door closed. Christians still divide over this, and readers of this book will hold different views. What is worth learning from Simpson is not necessarily his conclusion but his method: he examined the Scriptures, sought God about it personally at real cost, refused to despise

believers whose experience differed from his own, and declined to make a secondary matter into a test of spirituality.

The evidence that is not disputed

Whatever one concludes about the gifts, Scripture is not ambiguous about what the Spirit's fullness produces.

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, temperance.

GALATIANS 5:22–23

But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me.

ACTS 1:8

Character and witness. Simpson's rule of thumb was that a man filled with the Spirit becomes more like Christ and more useful to Christ, and that any claimed fullness which produces neither should be examined rather than celebrated.

The most practical thing in this chapter is the inventory. Before asking for more, find out what is occupying the room.

Power for what

A question worth asking of the whole subject: what is the fullness for?

The promise in Acts answers it, and the answer is narrower than we sometimes assume.

But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.

ACTS 1:8

The power is given for witness. Not for personal exhilaration, not for a sense of spiritual arrival, and not for standing among other Christians. It is equipment for a task, and the task is other people.

Simpson pressed this hard, because he had watched the deeper life become, in some hands, an elaborate form of self-cultivation — believers pursuing ever richer inward experiences while the city outside remained unevangelised and the poor remained unvisited.

The test he applied is simple. Has this fullness made you more useful to anybody?

The manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal.

1 CORINTHIANS 12:7

To profit withal — for the common good. Every genuine work of the Spirit in an individual is intended to arrive somewhere else.

There is a mercy in this framing. A believer anxious about whether he has been filled can stop examining his sensations and ask a more

answerable question: since last year, has anyone been helped through me who would not otherwise have been?

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Take an honest inventory of what fills you. Name one thing displacing the Spirit and deal with it before asking for anything.
2. Ask plainly, on the strength of Luke 11:13, and then act as though God has answered rather than waiting for a sensation.
3. Test any claimed fullness — your own included — by Galatians 5:22 and Acts 1:8. Character and witness.
4. Where you differ from other Christians about the gifts, adopt Simpson's posture: study honestly, seek God personally, refuse contempt.
5. Renew the filling daily. It is a continuous command, not a certificate.

A PRAYER

Holy Spirit, I have asked for more of You when the problem was how much of me was already occupied.

Show me what fills the room. Empty me of the ambition, the grudge, the appetite, the self-pity that leaves so little space.

I ask, because my Father has promised to give You to those who ask. I take You at Your word, whether or not I feel anything.

Make me more like Christ and more useful to Him. Let those be the evidences, and let me not despise any believer whose experience differs from mine. Amen.

A Larger Christian Life

*Enlarge the place of thy tent ...spare not, lengthen thy cords, and
strengthen thy stakes.*

ISAIAH 54:2

Simpson gave one of his books the title *A Larger Christian Life*, and the phrase captures a conviction that runs through everything he did: that most believers are living in a smaller world than God has provided, and that the limitation is entirely on our side.

Straitened in ourselves

His controlling text was a remark of Paul's to a difficult congregation.

*O ye Corinthians, our mouth is open unto you, our heart is enlarged. Ye are not
straitened in us, but ye are straitened in your own bowels.*

2 CORINTHIANS 6:11–12

Straitened means narrowed, cramped, confined. Paul tells them that whatever constriction they feel in the relationship is not coming from his end. He is wide open. The narrowness is theirs.

Simpson applied this to our dealings with God, and the application is uncomfortable. When our Christian life feels small — when God seems distant, prayer feels mechanical, and the supply appears inadequate — our instinct is to conclude that heaven is being sparing. The apostle's diagnosis points the other way. The pipe is not narrow at the source.

*I am the Lord thy God, which brought thee out of the land of Egypt: open thy
mouth wide, and I will fill it.*

PSALM 81:10

That is an extraordinary invitation, and Simpson observed that most of us respond to it with a very modest request and then complain about the size of the answer.

Three enlargements

He worked the theme out in several directions, and three are worth naming.

Larger views of God. Almost every spiritual problem, Simpson thought, traces back to a God who has been mentally reduced — made manageable, predictable, and roughly the size of our own experience. The remedy is not technique but sight.

*Now unto him that is able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or
think, according to the power that worketh in us.*

Note where Paul sets the ceiling: not at what we ask, which would be generous, but above what we can even conceive of asking. Any request we bring is therefore beneath the limit by definition.

Larger faith. Simpson observed that we tend to ask God for what we can already imagine arranging ourselves, with a small margin added for divine assistance. He urged believers to ask for things that would be embarrassing if God did not act — and then to be willing to wait.

Larger service. His own life is the argument. He had a comfortable pulpit and gave it up to work among people who could not pay him, and the result was a movement on several continents. He held that most Christians are prevented from any significant usefulness not by lack of gifting but by the smallness of what they have offered.

Enlargement is not always comfortable

The honest half of the chapter, which Simpson did not hide.

The verse in Isaiah tells the tent-dweller to lengthen the cords *and* strengthen the stakes. A larger tent needs deeper anchoring, or the first storm takes it. Enlargement of capacity is generally accompanied by enlargement of pressure, and God rarely gives one without the other.

Simpson's own enlargements came through a nervous collapse, a heart condition, a resignation that cost him his income and his denomination, the burial of children, and the loss of friends on both sides of a controversy he did not start. He was not describing an easier life. He was describing a bigger one.

Thou hast enlarged me when I was in distress.

PSALM 4:1

That is the honest order in most lives. The distress comes first, and the enlargement is what God does with it.

There is a diagnostic worth applying.

Look at what you asked God for this month. Would any of it have required Him to act? Or could most of it have happened through ordinary competence and reasonable luck?

The answer tells you the size of the tent you are living in, and it is not a verdict on God's supply.

Enlarged towards people

The enlargement Simpson pressed hardest was not in faith or service but in affection, because it is the one we are least willing to attempt.

And the Lord make you to increase and abound in love one toward another, and toward all men.

1 THESSALONIANS 3:12

Paul's prayer has two directions, and the second is the difficult one. *One toward another* covers the people we already like. *Toward all men* does not.

Simpson observed that most Christians have a heart of a fixed size, into which a certain number of people fit, and that we manage the limit by quietly excluding those who are difficult, tedious, foreign, poor, or who have wronged us. The exclusions are never announced; they are simply operated.

His prescription was not to feel differently, which nobody can produce on demand, but to act deliberately in the direction of the enlargement and let the affection follow. Speak to the person you have been avoiding. Give to someone who cannot reciprocate. Take an interest in a country you have never thought about.

Now for a recompence in the same, (I speak as unto my children,) be ye also enlarged.

2 CORINTHIANS 6:13

There is a connection here with everything else in the chapter that is easy to miss. A cramped heart towards people generally accompanies a cramped view of God, because our sense of how much we have received governs how freely we give. The person who believes he has been forgiven a great deal finds it strangely easy to be generous, and the person who believes he was not that bad to begin with finds it strangely hard.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Review your recent prayers. How many required God to do something you could not arrange?
2. Ask for one thing this month that would be plainly embarrassing if God did not act. Then wait without withdrawing the request.
3. Identify where you have concluded that God is being sparing. Consider Paul's diagnosis instead: the narrowness may be at your end.
4. Offer something larger — more time, more money, a willingness you have been withholding — and see what God does with it.
5. Strengthen the stakes as well as lengthening the cords. Deepen a discipline before you seek a wider ministry.

A PRAYER

Father, I have lived in a small tent and blamed the weather.

You are able to do exceeding abundantly above all that I ask or think, and my asking has been careful, modest and mostly within reach of my own competence. Forgive the smallness of it.

Enlarge me — my view of You, my expectation, my service, my heart towards people I find difficult.

*And when the enlargement comes through distress, as it usually does, hold me steady.
Lengthen my cords, but strengthen my stakes. Amen.*

The Life of Faith

Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.

HEBREWS 11:1

Everything in Simpson's teaching is received the same way, and it is worth setting out how he understood the receiving.

Faith is a definite act

His characteristic emphasis was that faith is not a mood but a transaction — something a believer does at a particular moment, on the strength of something God has said.

His own healing is the pattern. He did not drift into a general confidence about his health. He went into the woods, settled the scriptural question, and made a definite pledge: taking Christ then and there as the life of his body. He wrote it down. He dated it. Afterwards, when symptoms returned, he did not renegotiate — he referred back to a transaction already completed.

He staggered not at the promise of God through unbelief; but was strong in faith, giving glory to God; and being fully persuaded that, what he had promised, he was able also to perform.

ROMANS 4:20–21

Simpson urged believers to make such transactions explicitly rather than hoping vaguely. A vague faith cannot be tested, cannot be remembered, and cannot be stood upon when feelings change — which they will.

Faith rests on a word, not on itself

The distinction that keeps this from becoming dangerous is where faith is placed.

Faith is not a force we generate, and its power does not lie in its intensity. It lies entirely in its object. A weak grip on a strong rope is safer than a fierce grip on nothing.

So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

ROMANS 10:17

Which means the way to increase faith is not to try to believe harder. It is to find out what God has actually said, since faith is produced by the Word rather than by effort. Simpson's counsel to the struggling was

always to send them back to a specific promise rather than to exhort them to greater conviction.

He also distinguished sharply between faith and presumption. Faith takes hold of something God has promised. Presumption takes hold of something we want and attaches God's name to it. The difference is not the strength of the confidence — presumption is often more confident — but whether there is a word from God underneath.

And this is the confidence that we have in him, that, if we ask any thing according to his will, he heareth us.

1 JOHN 5:14

Faith and feeling

Simpson returned constantly to the order of these two, because reversing them had wrecked so many.

The natural sequence we want is: feel, then believe. God's sequence is: believe, and the feeling follows or does not, and either way the fact stands.

His own conversion was the first lesson in this. He took Christ at fifteen with no emotion whatever and spent some time troubled by the absence, until he understood that he had been looking for evidence in the wrong place. He built the rest of his life on that order.

For we walk by faith, not by sight.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:7

An honest caution

Teaching of this kind has a shadow, and it must be named.

When faith is presented as the decisive factor, a believer whose prayer is not answered can only conclude that his faith was insufficient — and from there it is a short step to a religion of anxious self-examination, and a shorter one to telling the suffering that their trouble is their own fault.

Simpson himself was more careful than some of his followers, but the danger is real and this book has already met it in chapter four. Three guards are necessary.

Faith is God's gift, not our achievement — *it is the gift of God* (Ephesians 2:8). Its measure is not a moral score.

Unanswered prayer is not proof of unbelief. Paul asked three times and was refused, and no one has ever suggested his faith was defective.

And the object of faith is a Person with His own wisdom, not a mechanism that delivers on demand. The father in Mark 9 who said he believed and asked for help with his unbelief received exactly what he asked for, which suggests that God's threshold is lower than ours.

Lord, I believe; help thou mine unbelief.

Faith, then, is neither a feeling nor a force. It is taking God at His word, in a definite act, about a specific thing He has actually said — and then behaving as though it were true, because it is.

Faith puts its foot in the water

Faith, in Scripture, characteristically acts before it sees — and Simpson's favourite illustration was the crossing of Jordan.

The river was in flood. The instruction given to the priests carrying the ark was that they should step into the water, and that the waters would then be cut off.

And it shall come to pass, as soon as the soles of the feet of the priests ...shall rest in the waters of Jordan ...the waters of Jordan shall be cut off.

JOSHUA 3:13

The order is unmistakable. The feet go in first; the river parts afterwards. Had the priests waited for evidence that the promise was reliable, they would have stood on the bank for the rest of their lives.

Simpson applied this to the sticking point in most Christian experience. We wait for the assurance before we act, and God has arranged matters so that the assurance arrives in the acting.

Yea, a man may say, Thou hast faith, and I have works: shew me thy faith without thy works, and I will shew thee my faith by my works.

JAMES 2:18

James is not correcting Paul. He is describing the same faith from the outside. What cannot be seen directly can be inferred from what a person actually does, and a faith that never issues in an act cannot be distinguished from an opinion.

The practical counsel is uncomfortable and short. Identify the step you have been waiting to feel ready for. Note that you have been waiting a considerable time. Take it.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Find a specific promise of God that covers your present need. Not a general impression — a text.
2. Make a definite transaction about it: put it in words, write the date, and tell God you are taking Him at His word.
3. When feelings contradict it later, do not renegotiate. Refer back.
4. Test whether you are exercising faith or presumption. Is there a word from God underneath, or only something you want?

5. If your faith feels small, pray Mark 9:24 exactly as it stands. It was answered.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have called it faith when it was only hoping, and I have wondered why nothing was settled.

Show me what You have actually promised. Let my confidence rest on Your word and not on the strength of my own believing.

I take You at Your word today about the thing I have brought You. When my feelings say otherwise, hold me to what was settled.

And where my faith is small, I say what the father said: I believe; help my unbelief. You did not turn him away. Amen.

The Life of Prayer

Men ought always to pray, and not to faint.

LUKE 18:1

Simpson built a movement, a college, a magazine and a missionary society, and he maintained throughout that none of it was the real work. The real work was prayer, and everything visible was the overflow.

Communion before petition

His first insistence was that prayer is fellowship before it is request.

We generally reverse this. Prayer, for most of us, is the department of the Christian life where we bring needs, and its health is measured by whether the needs are met. On that basis a season of unanswered prayer feels like a failed relationship, because the relationship was constructed entirely around transactions.

Simpson taught believers to begin by attending to God Himself — which is simply chapter one applied to the prayer closet. Petition follows, and belongs there, but it is not the foundation.

But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret.

MATTHEW 6:6

The instruction is about a Person and a door, not a list.

Abiding prayer

His governing text for the whole subject came from the vine discourse, and he would not let the first clause be detached from the second.

If ye abide in me, and my words abide in you, ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you.

JOHN 15:7

The promise at the end is breathtaking, and it is conditioned twice. The one who abides in Christ, and in whom Christ's words abide, will find his asking answered — because such a person's wants have been progressively reshaped. He is not receiving a blank cheque; he has become someone who wants what God wants.

Simpson drew from this that the way to improve one's prayer life is largely indirect. Time spent in the Word alters what one asks for, and the alteration does more for the answered-prayer rate than any refinement of technique.

Ye ask, and receive not, because ye ask amiss, that ye may consume it upon your lusts.

JAMES 4:3

Asking, and taking

Here is a distinction characteristic of Simpson, and it follows from the last chapter.

He distinguished between the prayer of supplication — asking, and continuing to ask, for something not yet given — and the prayer of faith, in which the believer, having found a promise and become settled, takes what God has offered and moves from petition to thanksgiving.

Therefore I say unto you, What things soever ye desire, when ye pray, believe that ye receive them, and ye shall have them.

MARK 11:24

Note the tense. *Believe that ye receive* — at the point of asking, before anything is visible.

Simpson was careful to keep both kinds. He did not teach that persistent asking is a sign of weak faith; the Lord's own parables commend the widow who would not stop. But he held that there comes a point, on some matters, when the believer has heard from God and may stop asking and start thanking — and that many Christians never arrive there because they have never settled what God has actually said.

Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God.

PHILIPPIANS 4:6

With thanksgiving — before the answer, not after it.

Praying in the Spirit

Simpson connected prayer directly to the indwelling Spirit, and this rescued the subject from being a matter of human exertion.

Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit.

EPHESIANS 6:18

Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us.

ROMANS 8:26

The admission in that verse — *we know not what we should pray for* — was, in Simpson's view, one of the most liberating in Scripture. We are not required to diagnose situations correctly before we may pray about them. The Spirit within supplies what we lack, including the content.

This also accounts for the burdens that come upon praying people: a name that will not leave the mind, a persistent concern for a country or a person. Simpson took these seriously as the Spirit's prompting, while

cautioning that they must never be treated as revelation or allowed to override Scripture.

Prayer and the nations

One further note, because it explains the shape of his ministry.

Simpson's prayer life was heavily occupied with places he would never see. He prayed for countries by name, for workers by name, and he taught his congregation to do the same. The Missionary Training Institute began in prayer meetings; so did the Alliance.

Ask of me, and I shall give thee the heathen for thine inheritance, and the uttermost parts of the earth for thy possession.

PSALM 2:8

He regarded that as an invitation extended to the church, and he took it literally.

The most useful practical counsel he gave about prayer was also the least inspiring: keep an appointment.

Feeling will not sustain it. A fixed time, kept whether or not anything is felt, outlasts every burst of enthusiasm — and it is generally in the unfelt sessions that the real work is done.

Hindrances

Simpson gave attention to the question every praying person eventually asks: when prayer seems to meet a ceiling, is there anything to look for?

Scripture names several things, and he worked through them plainly rather than spiritualising the difficulty.

Unconfessed sin. The most direct statement in the Psalms is also the bluntest.

If I regard iniquity in my heart, the Lord will not hear me.

PSALM 66:18

The word is *regard* — not commit, but harbour and protect. The issue is not failure but tolerance.

Unforgiveness. The Lord attached this directly to prayer, in a passage about mountains being moved.

And when ye stand praying, forgive, if ye have ought against any.

MARK 11:25

Domestic discord. Peter tells husbands to treat their wives with honour so that their prayers be not hindered (1 Peter 3:7). Simpson noted how few believers connect the state of their marriage with the state of their prayer life, and how explicitly Scripture does.

Wrong motive — asking in order to spend it on ourselves (James 4:3). And **unsettled doubt** — the double-minded man who asks and

does not expect (James 1:6–7).

He added a necessary caution. This list is not to be used as a diagnostic tool on other people's unanswered prayers, and not every silence has a cause we can locate. Some delays are the exercise of faith, and some are simply the wisdom of God, who occasionally answers no. The list is for personal examination, and it should be worked through honestly and then left alone.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Begin your next prayer time with ten minutes that contain no requests at all.
2. Fix an appointment and keep it on the days you do not feel like it, especially those.
3. Take one matter you have been asking about for months. Find what God has said about it, and consider whether it is time to move from asking to thanking.
4. Pray for one country and one worker by name this week. Keep it up for a month.
5. When you do not know how to pray about something, say so, and ask the Spirit to supply what you lack.

A PRAYER

Father, I have treated prayer as a place to bring needs, and when the needs were unmet I concluded that something had failed.

Teach me to come for You before I come for anything.

Let Your words abide in me until what I ask for has quietly changed. Where you have spoken, give me the boldness to stop asking and begin thanking.

And when I do not know what to pray, pray in me by Your Spirit — for people I have forgotten, and for nations I will never see. Amen.

Christ in All the Scriptures

And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself.

LUKE 24:27

Simpson's largest literary undertaking was a commentary on the whole Bible, and its title states his method: *Christ in the Bible*. He worked through book after book asking one question of each — where is Christ here?

The Lord's own method

He took his warrant from the road to Emmaus.

Two disciples are walking away from Jerusalem in complete confusion, and the risen Christ, unrecognised, gives them a Bible study. He does not begin with the resurrection appearances. He begins at Moses, works through the prophets, and shows them the things concerning Himself in all the Scriptures.

And he said unto them, These are the words which I spake unto you ...that all things must be fulfilled, which were written in the law of Moses, and in the prophets, and in the psalms, concerning me.

LUKE 24:44

Simpson pointed out that this covers the entire Hebrew canon in its three divisions. The claim is not that the Old Testament contains a few messianic predictions. It is that the whole thing is about Him.

Search the scriptures; for in them ye think ye have eternal life: and they are they which testify of me.

JOHN 5:39

Then said I, Lo, I come: in the volume of the book it is written of me.

HEBREWS 10:7

Types and shadows

Simpson's practice was to look for Christ in three ways.

In **prophecy** — the direct predictions, from the seed of the woman in Genesis 3 to the messenger of the covenant at the close of Malachi.

In **type** — persons, institutions and events that prefigure Him. The New Testament does this itself and thereby licenses the method: Adam is called a figure of Him that was to come; Melchizedek is expounded at length in Hebrews; the passover lamb, the brazen serpent, the rock in

the wilderness, the sacrifices and the tabernacle are all applied to Christ by New Testament writers.

For even Christ our passover is sacrificed for us.

1 CORINTHIANS 5:7

And in the **names and titles** — a study Simpson loved. He wrote a whole book on the names of Jesus, holding that each reveals a distinct relation in which He meets a distinct need.

Why this matters practically

Three consequences, and Simpson pressed all of them.

It **unifies the Bible**. Many believers experience Scripture as two disconnected books, and quietly abandon most of the first. If Christ is the subject throughout, the whole becomes coherent.

It **keeps the Old Testament from moralism**. Read without Christ, the narratives become a gallery of examples: be brave like David, be pure like Joseph, be patient like Job. Simpson regarded that as a subtle return to salvation by imitation. The stories are not primarily about how to behave; they point to One who did what none of the characters could.

And it **feeds devotion**. A believer who has learned to look for Christ in every passage will not run dry, because the subject is inexhaustible.

That I may know him, and the power of his resurrection, and the fellowship of his sufferings.

PHILIPPIANS 3:10

The necessary caution

Honesty requires a warning, because this method has a well-known failure mode and Simpson does not always avoid it.

Typology can be pressed until every detail becomes a symbol and the interpreter is no longer reading the text but decorating it. Once the discipline goes, a man can find whatever he brought with him, and the Bible ceases to be able to correct him — which is precisely the opposite of what Scripture is for.

The safeguards are straightforward. Follow the New Testament's own examples rather than inventing new ones. Establish what a passage meant in its own setting before asking what it foreshadows; the two are not rivals, but the order matters. Hold typological readings as illumination rather than doctrine, and never build a teaching on a shadow that is not stated plainly somewhere in the light.

Applied with those, the method is one of the great gifts of the older expositors, and it has largely been lost.

Try it once and the appeal becomes obvious. Take a passage you find dull — Leviticus, a genealogy, a chapter of Kings — and ask the Emmaus question: where is Christ here?

You will not always find a clean answer. You will not read that chapter the same way again.

The names of God

One of Simpson's favourite exercises was tracing the compound names of God through the Old Testament, and reading each as a disclosure of what Christ would prove to be.

Where Abraham found a ram caught in a thicket, the place was named for the God who provides.

And Abraham called the name of that place Jehovahjireh: as it is said to this day, In the mount of the Lord it shall be seen.

GENESIS 22:14

The bitter water at Marah was healed, and God revealed Himself there as the One who heals (Exodus 15:26). After the victory over Amalek, Moses built an altar and called it *the Lord my banner* (Exodus 17:15). Gideon, terrified, was met by *the Lord send peace* (Judges 6:24). The shepherd psalm opens with *the Lord is my shepherd*, and Ezekiel closes with a city whose name means *the Lord is there*.

Simpson's method was to place each beside a corresponding claim of Christ. The God who provides; and *my God shall supply all your need* (Philippians 4:19). The God who heals; and the One who went about healing. The banner; and *thanks be to God, which giveth us the victory* (1 Corinthians 15:57). The peace; and *he is our peace* (Ephesians 2:14). The shepherd; and *I am the good shepherd* (John 10:11). The Lord who is there; and *lo, I am with you always*.

The value of the exercise is not scholarly but devotional. It supplies a vocabulary for bringing a specific need to a specific aspect of Christ, and it demonstrates the continuity Simpson was always insisting upon: that the God who met His people at Marah and Peniel and Bethlehem is the same, and has not changed His character between the Testaments.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Read Luke 24:13–32 and notice what the risen Christ chose to do with two confused disciples.
2. Take one Old Testament passage this week and ask where Christ is in it. Write down what you find.
3. Check your Old Testament reading for moralism. Are you mostly extracting examples to imitate?

4. Study one name or title of Christ — Shepherd, Advocate, Bread, Rock — and trace it across both Testaments.
5. Keep the guard-rails: follow the New Testament's own typology, and never build doctrine on a shadow alone.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You walked with two disconsolate men and opened the Scriptures until their hearts burned, and the subject was Yourself.

I have read large parts of Your Word as history, or as a set of examples to copy, and missed You in them.

Open the Scriptures to me. Let me find You in the law and the prophets and the psalms, in the sacrifices and the shadows and the names.

And keep me sober. Let me not find what I brought with me; let me find You. Amen.

Days of Heaven Upon Earth

That your days may be multiplied ...as the days of heaven upon the earth.

DEUTERONOMY 11:21

Simpson's daily devotional, still in print more than a century later, takes its title from a phrase in Deuteronomy: days of heaven upon the earth.

The promise was made to Israel about life in the land. Simpson took it as a description of what the indwelling Christ makes possible in ordinary time — not an escape from earth, and not a postponement until heaven, but a quality of daily life that belongs to another country.

Not escape, but transformation

It is worth being clear about what he was not saying.

He was not describing a life without difficulty. His own contained a nervous collapse, a heart condition, financial insecurity, the loss of children, public controversy and a dark final illness. Whatever days of heaven upon earth meant to him, it plainly did not mean pleasant circumstances.

Nor was he recommending detachment — the spirituality that copes with the world by withdrawing attention from it. Simpson was one of the most engaged men of his generation, running rescue missions and orphanages and sending workers to the hardest places on the map.

What he meant was that the ordinary day — the same day, with the same trouble in it — is transformed when it is lived in company with Someone.

Thou wilt keep him in perfect peace, whose mind is stayed on thee: because he trusteth in thee.

ISAIAH 26:3

The peace there is not the absence of trouble but the presence of a settled mind, and the condition is a direction of attention.

Moment by moment

Simpson's practical counsel centred on the smallness of the unit.

We tend to think of the spiritual life in large blocks — a good year, a bad season, a period of dryness. He taught believers to think in moments, because a moment is the only thing anyone can actually manage.

Take therefore no thought for the morrow: for the morrow shall take thought for the things of itself. Sufficient unto the day is the evil thereof.

MATTHEW 6:34

The grace supplied is for today, and attempting to face next month's difficulty with today's supply is the commonest cause of Christian exhaustion. Simpson pointed out that Israel's manna could not be stored, and that this was a mercy rather than an inconvenience.

As thy days, so shall thy strength be.

DEUTERONOMY 33:25

The habit of turning

The practice he recommended is simple enough to be dismissed and difficult enough to take years.

It is the habit of turning inwardly to Christ throughout the day — not extended prayer, but a repeated brief recognition that He is present and available: at the start of a task, in the middle of an interruption, before a difficult conversation, on waking in the night.

Because he is at my right hand, I shall not be moved.

PSALM 16:8

Simpson held that this practice, sustained, does more for the quality of a life than any amount of intense but occasional devotion. The person who meets God only in a set half-hour has a religious appointment. The person who has learned to turn has a companion.

Joy as evidence

He gave joy a prominent place, and treated its absence as a symptom worth investigating rather than a temperament to be accepted.

These things have I spoken unto you, that my joy might remain in you, and that your joy might be full.

JOHN 15:11

Note whose joy it is. Not a joy we manufacture about our circumstances — His joy, remaining in us. Which means it is not dependent on our circumstances being joyful, and it survives conditions that would extinguish anything we generated ourselves.

A caution, though, and Simpson's own last years supply it. He passed through a period of genuine spiritual darkness at the end of his life, and his friends found it painful to watch in a man who had taught so many about victory. That should be said honestly. Believers experience depression, illness of the mind, and long stretches of dryness, and it is not always a spiritual failure to be corrected. Sometimes it is a burden to be borne, with help, and God does not love such a person less.

The invitation of this chapter is modest and immediate. Not a better year. Today — this afternoon, the next hour — lived in company with

Christ.

The discipline of thanksgiving

If one practice above others changes the texture of an ordinary day, Simpson held it was deliberate thanksgiving — and he treated it as a discipline rather than a mood.

In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:18

Two things about that command are worth noticing.

It is a command, which means it is not conditional on feeling grateful. We can give thanks in the absence of the sensation, and the sensation often follows the practice rather than preceding it.

And it is *in* every thing, not *for* every thing. Simpson was careful here, because the distinction protects the sufferer. We are not required to call evil good, to describe a bereavement as a blessing, or to pretend that a diagnosis is welcome. We are required to find God present in the middle of it, and to say so.

I will bless the Lord at all times: his praise shall continually be in my mouth.

PSALM 34:1

The practical form he recommended was specific rather than general. Vague gratitude for blessings in the abstract does very little; naming three particular things, out loud, does a surprising amount — and it works best on the days when the list is hardest to assemble.

He connected this directly to the theme of the chapter. Heaven is a place of unbroken thanksgiving. A believer who is learning the habit now is not merely improving his mood; he is practising the native language of the country he is travelling to.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Practise turning inwardly to Christ at three fixed points tomorrow: before work, at a meal, and before something you are dreading.
2. Stop trying to face next month with today's grace. Ask only for today.
3. When joy is absent, investigate rather than accepting it as your personality — and if the darkness persists, seek help without shame.
4. Take one dull, ordinary hour and consciously invite Christ into it. Notice what changes and what does not.
5. Read Deuteronomy 33:25 slowly on a day when your strength feels inadequate for what is ahead.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have been waiting for a better season, and You have offered me this afternoon.

Teach me to turn to You in the small units — the interruption, the awkward conversation, the tiredness at three o'clock — rather than saving You for a set half hour.

Let Your joy remain in me, not a cheerfulness I have to manufacture.

And on the days when there is only darkness, hold me anyway, and let me not conclude that You have gone. Amen.

The Least of These

*Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren,
ye have done it unto me.*

MATTHEW 25:40

In the autumn of 1881, A. B. Simpson asked the Thirteenth Street Presbyterian Church in New York to receive into membership a group of Italian immigrants who had been converted through his ministry.

The congregation declined.

He resigned. He was thirty-seven, with a family to support, and he gave up a distinguished pulpit, a settled salary and the denomination in which he had been raised and ordained. He had no congregation to go to and no income arranged.

Everything he built afterwards grew out of that refusal.

The gospel and the unwanted

The conviction behind it had been forming for years. In Louisville he had built a plain tabernacle rather than a handsome church, on the reasoning that working men who owned no respectable clothes would not come where they would be conspicuous. It was a small architectural decision with a large theology behind it.

The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he hath anointed me to preach the gospel to the poor.

LUKE 4:18

Simpson observed that the churches of his day were arranged, without anyone having decided it, for people like themselves. Pew rents, respectable dress, a manner of speech and an unspoken social threshold combined to make the gospel inaccessible to precisely the people it had first been preached to.

He regarded this as a direct violation of an apostolic command.

My brethren, have not the faith of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Lord of glory, with respect of persons ...Are ye not then partial in yourselves, and are become judges of evil thoughts?

JAMES 2:1, 4

James's example is a congregation that seats a well-dressed visitor comfortably and leaves a poor one standing. Simpson's point was that we no longer do this crudely, and do it all the time.

What he actually built

The Gospel Tabernacle became a working demonstration. Around it grew rescue missions for the destitute, work among prostitutes, an orphanage, homes where the sick could stay and be cared for and prayed over, and services conducted in the languages of the immigrants pouring into the city.

None of this replaced preaching. Simpson would have regarded the suggestion as absurd; he was preaching several times a week and writing continuously throughout. But he did not regard practical mercy as a separate department either, or as a means to secure a hearing for the real message. It was part of the message.

Pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father is this, To visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction, and to keep himself unspotted from the world.

JAMES 1:27

Both, and neither reduced

There is a caution to state, because the century after Simpson divided badly on exactly this point.

One wing of the church reduced Christianity to social improvement and quietly lost the gospel of the cross, until it had nothing to offer anyone that a competent charity could not offer better. Another wing reacted by treating practical mercy with suspicion, as a distraction from soul-winning — and produced congregations that could explain justification and would not have noticed a hungry family in the next street.

Simpson held both without apparent strain, and the reason is his Fourfold Gospel. A Christ who saves the soul, sanctifies the character, heals the body and is coming to reign over the earth cannot be confined to any single department of human need. The whole person is in view, and so is the whole world.

Whoso hath this world's good, and seeth his brother have need, and shutteth up his bowels of compassion from him, how dwelleth the love of God in him?

1 JOHN 3:17

The identification

The text at the head of this chapter contains the sharpest claim in the New Testament about the poor, and Simpson took it at face value.

The King does not say that serving the hungry, the stranger, the sick and the prisoner is *like* serving Him, or that He approves of it. He says it was done to Him. There is an identification here so complete that the people in the parable are astonished — in both directions. Neither group knew.

For I was an hungred, and ye gave me meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me drink: I was a stranger, and ye took me in.

The uncomfortable question raised by Simpson's resignation is not whether your church would refuse a group of immigrant converts. Almost none would say so.

It is subtler than that. Who, in practice, is not here? Look around your congregation and ask which kinds of people are absent, and whether anything about the arrangements — the assumptions, the dress, the vocabulary, the unspoken thresholds — helps to explain it.

Money

Simpson's convictions about the poor were expensive, and it is worth saying how he handled money, because that is where such convictions are tested.

He resigned a comfortable salary with a family to support and never again held a position with guaranteed income. The Alliance operated on faith lines: no salaries promised, no debt incurred, and no appeals of the ordinary kind. Money came in and went out, and the needs were made known chiefly to God.

Whether every ministry should be run this way is a fair question, and Scripture does not require it — Paul accepted support and asked for it plainly. What is not optional is the underlying attitude, and Simpson's practice illustrates it.

Charge them that are rich in this world, that they be not highminded, nor trust in uncertain riches, but in the living God ...that they do good, that they be rich in good works, ready to distribute, willing to communicate.

1 TIMOTHY 6:17–18

He held up the Macedonian churches as the pattern, and the details of Paul's description are pointed: they were in deep poverty, their giving was beyond their means, they had to beg for the privilege, and the sequence began with giving themselves to the Lord first.

For to their power, I bear record, yea, and beyond their power they were willing of themselves.

2 CORINTHIANS 8:3

Note that they were the poor giving to the poor. Simpson observed that generosity is not a function of surplus, and that congregations which wait for prosperity before becoming generous generally discover that prosperity does not produce it either.

The test is not the amount but the effect. Giving that does not alter how you live has not yet begun.

1. Look honestly at who is absent from your congregation, and ask what in your arrangements might account for it.
2. Identify one person in your regular orbit whom you have quietly filed as not worth your time. Change that this week.
3. Do something practical and unremarkable for someone who cannot repay you and will not report it.
4. Check which reduction you drift towards — gospel without mercy, or mercy without gospel — and correct in the other direction.
5. Read Matthew 25:31–46 and let the astonishment of both groups do its work. Neither knew.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You were anointed to preach the gospel to the poor, and I have built a religion that is comfortable for people like me.

Forgive the respect of persons that I have never had to name because everyone around me shares it.

Show me who is missing, and why. Show me the person I have quietly decided is not worth my attention.

You said it was done to You. Let me believe that this week, in something small and unrecorded. Amen.

The Missionary Heart

*And how shall they hear without a preacher? and how shall they preach,
except they be sent?*

ROMANS 10:14–15

Simpson wanted to go to China. His family circumstances prevented it, and he never went anywhere as a missionary.

So he spent the rest of his life sending other people, and by the time he died there were several hundred of them scattered across places he had prayed for by name and never seen.

The obligation is the whole church's

His starting conviction was that the Great Commission was not addressed to specialists.

*Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father,
and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost.*

MATTHEW 28:19

In Simpson's day, foreign missions was largely the concern of denominational boards, staffed by highly trained men, funded through official channels, and regarded by most ordinary church members as something other people did. He thought this arrangement had no scriptural basis and was producing a fraction of the workers required.

His alternative was to make missions the business of the whole church — every member either going, sending, or praying, and none exempt.

Practical machinery

What distinguishes Simpson from other men with the same burden is that he built the machinery.

He founded a training school in 1882 — the first Bible institute in North America — on a deliberately unconventional principle. Seven years of classical education was an insuperable barrier for most people with a genuine call, and Simpson judged that it was not necessary. Give ordinary believers a thorough grounding in the Scriptures and practical training, in about two years, and get them to the field.

The idea was widely criticised as lowering the standard. It has since been copied by nearly every Bible college in the world.

He also organised the sending. The Alliance operated on faith lines — no guaranteed salaries, no debt, no appeals for money in the ordi-

nary sense — and it prioritised what Simpson called the neglected fields: places where no one else was working.

Yea, so have I strived to preach the gospel, not where Christ was named, lest I should build upon another man's foundation.

ROMANS 15:20

That verse governed his strategy. Where the gospel had already gone, others could build. The Alliance would go where nobody was.

The cost, stated honestly

It should not be presented as a romance. It was not.

Workers went to regions where the mortality rate for foreigners was appalling, and a significant number of them died within a few years, some within months, of disease. Others returned broken. Families were separated for years at a time, and children were sent home to be raised by relatives. The graves are real, and they are in the places Simpson prayed for.

He knew the arithmetic and kept sending, and the workers kept going. Whatever one makes of that, it is not the record of people playing at religion.

And they overcame him by the blood of the Lamb, and by the word of their testimony; and they loved not their lives unto the death.

REVELATION 12:11

Everyone is in one of three categories

Simpson's practical challenge to a congregation was that there is no fourth option.

You are **going** — taking the gospel yourself to a people who do not have it, whether across the world or across your own city.

You are **sending** — funding, at a level that affects how you live, the people who go.

You are **praying** — specifically, by name, for workers and for countries, and continuing when nothing appears to happen.

Most of us, examined honestly, are doing none of the three and assuming we are covered by general approval of the enterprise.

Also I heard the voice of the Lord, saying, Whom shall I send, and who will go for us? Then said I, Here am I; send me.

ISAIAH 6:8

There is one more thing worth noticing about Simpson's missionary passion, and it connects back to the first chapter of this book.

It was not fuelled by guilt, or by statistics, or by a sense of Western obligation. It was fuelled by the conviction that Christ is worthy — that a Person this glorious ought to be known everywhere, and that any nation which does not know Him has been robbed.

Missions, on that understanding, is not chiefly rescue. It is worship extended.

The nearest field

Simpson's missionary vision began at his own door, and the order in the commission is worth attending to.

And ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.

ACTS 1:8

Four circles, and the first is the city you are standing in. Simpson never treated the last as a substitute for the first. The same conviction that sent workers to inland China opened rescue missions a few streets from his own pulpit, and he would have regarded a congregation that supported missionaries abroad while ignoring the neglected nearby as having misread the verse.

He also noticed the middle term. Samaria, for a first-century Jerusalem believer, meant the people group next door that one avoided — close in geography and distant in sympathy. Every place has its Samaria, and it is usually the field the local church is least willing to enter, precisely because proximity makes the prejudice harder to disguise.

There is a development of this that Simpson saw beginning in New York and that has since transformed the picture. The nations were arriving. Immigrants from countries closed to missionaries were living within walking distance of churches that were praying for those countries and ignoring their citizens.

And hath made of one blood all nations of men for to dwell on all the face of the earth, and hath determined the times before appointed, and the bounds of their habitation; that they should seek the Lord.

ACTS 17:26–27

Paul's argument is that God arranges where peoples live, and does it with a purpose. If that is true, the presence of a diaspora community in your town is not an accident of economics. It is an assignment.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Determine which of the three you actually are — going, sending, praying — and be honest if the answer is none.
2. If you send, examine whether the amount affects how you live. If it does not, it is not yet sending in the New Testament sense.
3. Adopt one unreached people or one worker, and pray by name for a year.

4. Ask whether anything prevents you from going that is a preference rather than an obstacle.
5. Let the motive be Christ's worthiness rather than guilt. Guilt does not last; worship does.

A PRAYER

Lord of the harvest, I have approved of missions and contributed almost nothing to them.

I am not going, I am barely sending, and I do not pray for anyone by name. Forgive me for calling that a missionary heart.

Show me which of the three You are asking of me, and let me not negotiate.

And let the reason be Your worthiness — that You are too glorious to remain unknown among any people on earth. Amen.

Till He Comes

And this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; and then shall the end come.

MATTHEW 24:14

Everything in Simpson's life converged on one verse, and it is the one at the head of this chapter.

He read it as a task with a stated relation to the return of Christ, and it made him incapable of rest. The gospel is to reach all nations; then the end comes. The work is unfinished; therefore go.

A task with an end in view

Simpson's contemporaries who shared this conviction expressed it in a phrase that became the watchword of a generation: the evangelisation of the world in this generation. They believed it might be done, and done soon.

It was not. A century and more later the task remains unfinished, and the confident timetables of the 1890s look naive.

But the failure of the schedule does not touch the substance, and this is worth being clear about. The Lord did not say when. He said that it would happen, and He gave the command in the same breath as the promise of His presence.

Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world.

MATTHEW 28:20

The believer's business is not to calculate the completion date. It is to be found working when it arrives.

The end that is certain

What kept Simpson from despair at the size of the task was that he knew how it finishes. It is described, and the description is not ambiguous.

After this I beheld, and, lo, a great multitude, which no man could number, of all nations, and kindreds, and people, and tongues, stood before the throne, and before the Lamb, clothed with white robes, and palms in their hands.

REVELATION 7:9

Every nation. Every language. A multitude beyond counting. That is not a hope that the mission might succeed; it is a report of its outcome.

Which means the missionary enterprise is not a gamble. It is participation in something already certain. The only open question is who will have the privilege of being involved.

Hastening the day

There is a striking phrase in Peter that Simpson took seriously and that most readers pass over.

Looking for and hasting unto the coming of the day of God.

2 PETER 3:12

The margin of many Bibles renders it *hastening* the coming of that day. The idea that the church's obedience bears some relation to the timing of the end is difficult, and Christians have understood it differently. But Peter places it immediately after a statement about God's patience — that He is not willing that any should perish — which suggests the connection is precisely the one Simpson drew.

The Lord is not slack concerning his promise ...but is longsuffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance.

2 PETER 3:9

The delay is mercy. It exists so that people still outside may come in. Which is an argument for urgency and against impatience at the same time.

How it ended for him

Simpson's last years were hard. He grew frail and confused, passed through a season of spiritual darkness that distressed those who loved him, and stepped back from the movement he had founded. He died at Nyack on the twenty-ninth of October, 1919, at seventy-five.

He had spent nearly forty years telling people the King was coming soon. The King did not come in his lifetime, and Simpson died the way everyone does.

He left no money. He left a training school, a magazine, a hymnbook, a tabernacle full of poor people, and several hundred workers on fields he had never visited. The movement that grew from it is now largely made up of people in the countries he prayed for, and is considerably larger outside his own than within it.

He asked for that, and he did not see it, and it happened anyway.

Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye stedfast, unmoveable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord.

1 CORINTHIANS 15:58

The last word of the Bible on this subject is a request, and then a reply.

He which testifieth these things saith, Surely I come quickly. Amen. Even so, come, Lord Jesus.

REVELATION 22:20

Simpson spent his life on the interval between those two sentences. So do we all. The only question is what we do with it.

Living backward from that day

Simpson often urged his hearers to make decisions from the far end — to ask not what seems best now, but what will seem best then.

For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:10

This is not the judgment that determines salvation, which for the believer was settled at the cross. It is the assessment of a life's work, and Paul describes it elsewhere as a fire that tests what each has built.

If any man's work abide which he hath built thereupon, he shall receive a reward. If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire.

1 CORINTHIANS 3:14–15

Two things follow, and Simpson held both.

There is real security. *He himself shall be saved* — the believer whose work does not survive is not thereby lost. Nothing in this doctrine should produce terror in someone trusting Christ.

And there is real seriousness. It is possible to spend a Christian life on things that will not last, and to arrive with very little to show for a great deal of activity. Simpson thought most of us are in more danger of this than of gross sin, because it requires no decision — only drift.

The practical exercise he suggested is to project forward. Consider the thing occupying most of your energy at present, and ask honestly whether you expect to be glad of it on that day. Then consider the thing you keep postponing — the reconciliation, the giving, the going — and ask the same question.

The answers are usually available immediately, which is itself instructive.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Stop waiting for a clearer sense of the timetable. The command was given without one.
2. Take up one piece of unfinished work — a person, a place, a task — and commit to it for a year rather than a week.

3. Let Revelation 7:9 settle your discouragement. The outcome is reported, not hoped for.
4. Treat the delay as mercy for those not yet in, and let that shape how you speak of the world's condition.
5. Ask what you would want to be doing when He appears, and begin doing more of it this week.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You said the gospel would reach all nations, and then the end would come. I have believed that and lived as though it had nothing to do with me.

The task is unfinished. Show me my part of it, and let me not wait for certainty about the timing that You have declined to give.

Thank You that the outcome is not in doubt — that there will be a multitude from every nation and tongue before Your throne, and that no labour spent on that is wasted.

Keep me steadfast to the end. Even so, come, Lord Jesus. Amen.

Conclusion

Christ is all, and in all.

COLOSSIANS 3:11

Eighteen chapters can make it appear that A. B. Simpson taught a great many things. He taught one thing, and everything else is that one thing applied.

The one thing is this: *Christ Himself is the supply for every need a human being has, and He supplies it not by sending something but by being Someone within us.*

Follow it through and the whole structure appears. Christ our Saviour — He does not merely provide salvation, He is it, and He enters. Christ our Sanctifier — holiness is not achieved but received, because it is a Person. Christ our Healer — the same indwelling life reaching the body. Christ our Coming King — the Person we have received is the Person we shall see. The self life goes because the Christ life comes. The Spirit's whole work is to make this Christ real. Faith is how He is taken; prayer is fellowship with Him; the Scriptures are about Him; an ordinary Tuesday becomes a day of heaven because He is in it. And the reason to cross an ocean is that He is too glorious to remain unknown.

Four wheels, one chariot, one Person.

The danger of this book

If you have read this far, you are in some danger, and Simpson would have named it before anyone.

The peculiar risk of deeper-life teaching is that it can generate exactly the condition it was written to cure. A person reads about the fullness, the surrender, the land of promise — and sets off in pursuit of an experience. He attends the meeting, makes the consecration, has the feeling, and is empty six weeks later. So he tries again, and the cycle that Simpson escaped becomes the cycle this book has installed.

The whole point of his hymn is that the pursuit ends when the object changes. Not the blessing but the Lord. Not the feeling but the Word. Not the gift but the Giver.

But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves.

JAMES 1:22

So the plainest counsel this book can give is the same as in its companion volumes. Go back to the chapter that made you least comfort-

able — not the one you found most interesting. Take its application points and work them slowly over months. Then take the next.

Two things to carry

First, ask for Himself. Not for more of the Spirit, whom you already have. Not for a blessing you can describe. For Christ — and then go about your work without checking your feelings hourly to see whether it took.

Second, hold the four wheels together. Simpson's great gift to the church was proportion. In every generation, ministries are built on one emphasis, and the one emphasis eventually distorts everything else — healing without holiness, prophecy without evangelism, experience without doctrine, doctrine without compassion. Simpson's answer to the man who wanted him to specialise still stands: there are four wheels on the chariot, and three of them cannot be neglected for one.

A last word about the man

We have been honest about his failures.

His teaching on healing has done real damage where it was taken further than Scripture warrants, and some who followed him died of conditions that could have been treated. His confidence that the world might be evangelised in his own generation was mistaken. His framework of sanctification as a distinct crisis is disputed by serious Christians who read the same texts differently. And the man who taught so many about victory ended his own life in frailty, confusion and a season of spiritual darkness that those who loved him found hard to watch.

That last fact should not be tidied away, because it is pastorally important. If a man who taught the deeper life for forty years could finish in darkness, then darkness is not proof that someone has failed. It may simply be the end of a long race run by a body that is wearing out. God did not love him less in 1919 than in 1881.

None of this has been raised to diminish him. It has been raised because his own theology requires it. A teaching whose whole point is that we have nothing in ourselves and everything in Christ cannot be commended by pretending its teacher was an exception.

But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:7

He died at Nyack in the autumn of 1919, having spent forty years telling people that the King was coming soon. The King did not come in his lifetime.

He left no money. He left a training school that has been copied on every continent, a hymnbook, a magazine, a tabernacle full of the sort

of people other churches did not want, and several hundred workers in countries he had prayed for by name and never visited.

The movement that grew out of it is now far larger in those countries than in his own, and is made up overwhelmingly of people who have never heard of him.

He asked for exactly that. He did not see it. It happened anyway, which is the ordinary arrangement, and he would not have minded in the least — provided the credit went where it belonged.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, I have read about Your all-sufficiency, and I am capable of turning even that into one more experience to chase.

Keep me from it. I do not want the blessing; I want You. I do not want a fuller feeling; I want more of me to be Yours.

Be my salvation, my holiness, my strength, and my hope. Hold the four wheels of my life together, so that I do not become a person of one emphasis and no proportion.

And when my own strength fails at the end, as his did, hold me then too. Amen.

A Reader's Guide to A. B. Simpson

Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.

2 TIMOTHY 2:15

Simpson is easy to read and easy to obtain. He wrote for ordinary congregations rather than for scholars, his sentences are short, and his illustrations are plain. Everything he published is now in the public domain and a great deal of it is freely available online.

The difficulty is the opposite of the one Edwards presents. Simpson wrote a great deal, quickly, often for a weekly deadline, and the quality is uneven. Some volumes repeat one another. The guide below is arranged to save the reader time.

Begin here

The Fourfold Gospel. Short, and the best single entry point. The whole framework in a few dozen pages.

The Self Life and the Christ Life. His most searching practical book, and the basis of chapter six of this volume. If a reader wants to be uncomfortable in a useful way, this is the one.

Days of Heaven Upon Earth. A daily devotional, still in print after more than a century. The gentlest introduction to him and a good gift.

On the deeper life

Wholly Sanctified. A small book on 1 Thessalonians 5:23. Clear, warm and practical.

The Land of Promise. His exposition of the Canaan typology treated in chapter eight.

A Larger Christian Life. On enlargement of faith, service and expectation.

The Christ Life. Brief essays on union with Christ.

On the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit, or Power from on High, in two volumes, tracing the Spirit's work through the Old and New Testaments respectively. Long, but the fullest statement of the teaching in chapters nine and ten.

When the Comforter Came. Thirty-one short readings; much more accessible.

On prayer and Scripture

The Life of Prayer. Short and practical.

Christ in the Bible. His commentary on the whole Scripture, book by book, in many volumes, asking of each where Christ is found. Not to be read through; to be consulted alongside whatever you are studying.

The Names of Jesus. A study of the titles of Christ.

Approach with care

The Gospel of Healing (1885). The fullest statement of the teaching treated in chapter four of this book, and the volume that requires the cautions set out there. Simpson's own practice of setting aside medical means went beyond what Scripture teaches, and readers should not follow him in it. Read it alongside 2 Corinthians 12:7–10 and 2 Timothy 4:20.

The hymns

Simpson wrote more than a hundred, usually to be sung by his own congregation within days of being written. *Himself* is the essential one and states his whole theology; *Jesus Only* and *Yesterday, Today, Forever* are also widely known. They are worth reading as compressed teaching, not merely as devotional verse.

About Simpson

A. W. Tozer's *Wingspread* (1943) is the best-known life, written by the Alliance's most famous son. It is short, admiring, beautifully written, and not a critical biography.

A. E. Thompson's *The Life of A. B. Simpson* (1920) is the official account, published the year after his death, and valuable for its proximity to the events.

Charles Nienkirchen's *A. B. Simpson and the Pentecostal Movement* is the standard scholarly treatment of the tongues controversy discussed in chapter ten, and is more critical than the devotional lives.

Read more than one. The older biographies are written by people who loved him, and it shows in what they leave out.

Three counsels for reading him

Read him with the Bible open. Simpson claimed no authority of his own, and his method was to argue from texts. Check them.

Read him for the burden rather than the system. Where he presses a framework beyond what Scripture states — in the healing teaching, in the sanctification crisis, in the expectation of an imminent completion of the missionary task — take the pastoral concern and leave the scaffolding.

And read him slowly. His books are short and can be finished in an evening, which is precisely the danger. A chapter a week, acted on, will do more than the whole shelf admired.

Prove all things; hold fast that which is good.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:21